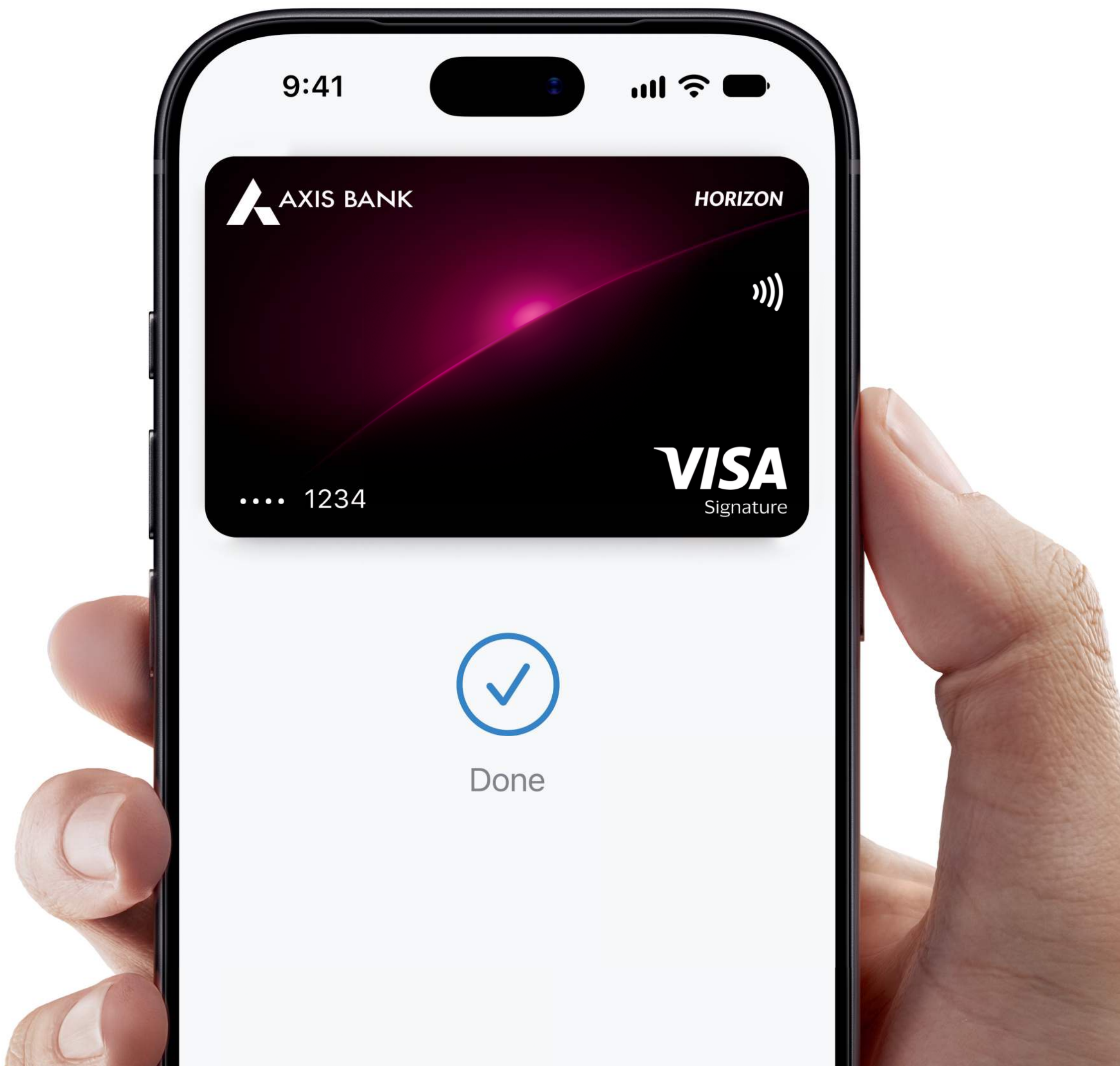




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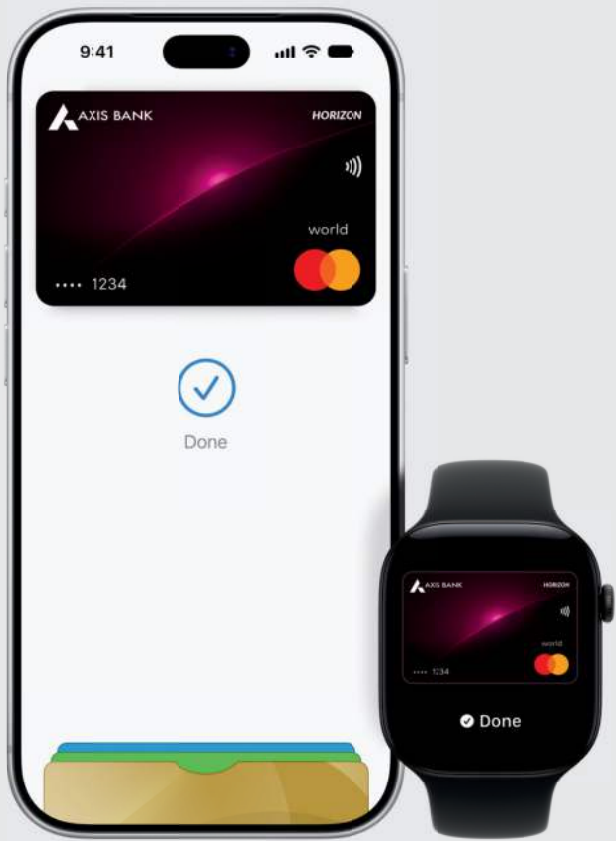


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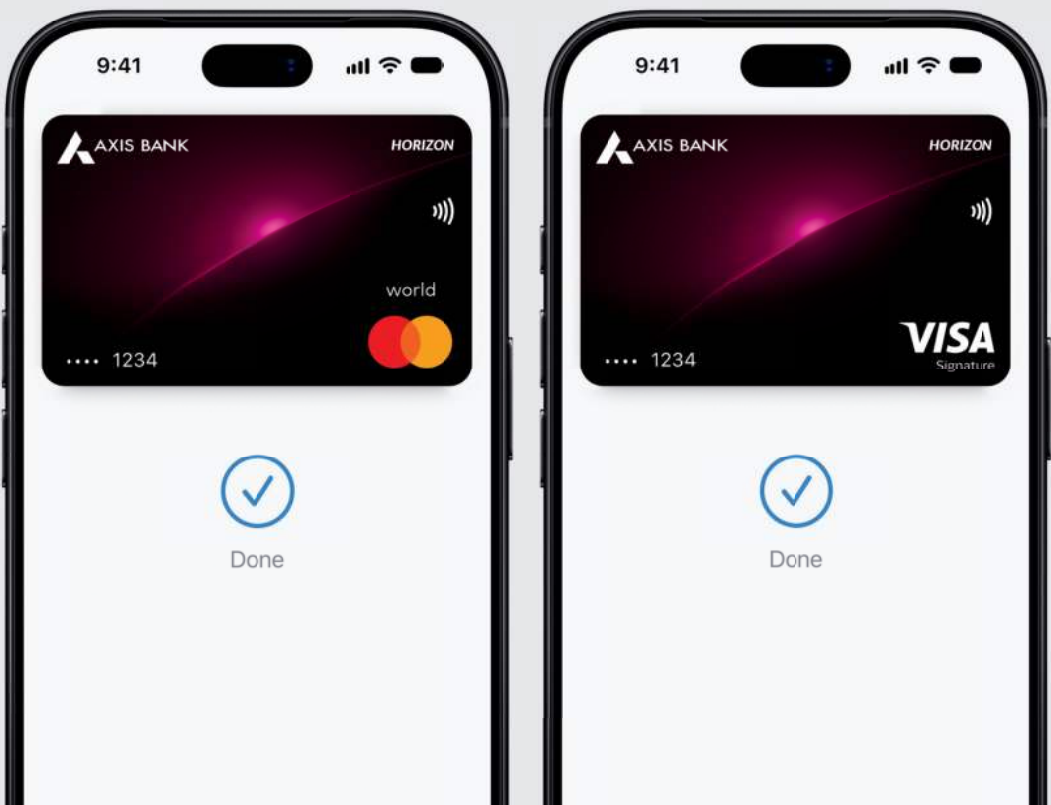


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MONDAY, 5 OCTOBER 2026

Keralam home minister has ordered a vigilance inquiry against CEC Gyanesh Kumar dating back to his state PWD secretary tenure in 2006 ▶ P 3

▶ US Deliberately Became a Lonelier Power; Russia Stood by India, says Jaishankar ▶ Indian Navyman Honey-trapped by Pakistani Spy, Leaks Data: P 4

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Fireflies' Krish Ramineni on AI Teammates and the Future of Knowledge

Himanshi Lochab speaks to Fireflies Krish Ramineni on AI Agents, the future of knowledge work, India's AI opportunity, and why falling AI costs could dramatically expand its adoption



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Tweet OF THE DAY



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Before you play a game, study the winners. If you wouldn't trade places with them, don't play their game.

Tech Buzz

SoftBank's Son Now Warns of AI Safety Risk

TOKYO: SoftBank Group chief Masayoshi Son – one of AI's fervent believers – said that even he's worried about safety risks as machines quickly gain more abilities. An exponential surge in AI capabilities makes it imperative for countries to build trust so that they can harness the technology together. Son said at an event on the sidelines of the Science and Technology in Society forum in Kyoto on Sunday. He was speaking alongside White House science and tech policy advisor Michael Kratsios. "We don't have any more luxury of having human fight against human," Son said, adding that countries need to work together to control the far greater threat from powerful AI models. Superintelligence in the wrong hands can become "super dangerous", SoftBank Group chief said. – Bloomberg

240,000

hacking attempts targeting the South Korean court network reported between January and August this year. – Agencies

Apple Tightens macOS Controls as AI Risks Rise

WASHINGTON: Apple said it plans to introduce new privacy controls for Mac users, warning of the growing risks around granting broad data access to third-party software, including artificial intelligence agents. The iPhone maker will introduce additional controls to ensure that users who want to grant an app 'Full Disk Access' – meaning full access to their system files, mail, messages and browsing history – can only do so "with very explicit user action", it said in a statement. "We are committed to ensuring users clearly understand these risks before granting such access, so they can make informed decisions about their own data and privacy," the company said. – Bloomberg

Jargon Buster

AI-horning

The annoying trend of forcing unnecessary artificial intelligence features into everyday apps and software

Forget AI Stall, Compute Constraint is the Real Threat: Menlo's Murphy

Portfolio sizing wins AI; young founders, not IT giants, will power India's future: Venky Ganesan

Samidha Sharma

San Francisco: Menlo Ventures, which first backed Anthropic in 2023 when the company was pre-product and pre-revenue, said a slowdown in frontier model development will not significantly affect foundation model companies or the overall market. Partner Matt Murphy, who led Menlo's investments in Anthropic, called the slowdown "a bit of a red herring," saying compute, not intelligence, is the real constraint. The frontier models "are already intelligent enough to serve the market in front of us, and that makes for an enormous market for all the AI companies," Murphy told ET in an interview at the San Francisco-based venture capital firm's headquarters in Menlo Park recently. A 20% or 30% slowing in pace, he said, would not have a dramatic impact on foundation model companies. Menlo bet the farm on Anthropic in 2024 when it led a \$750-million funding round in the AI startup at a valuation of about \$18.4 billion, writing the largest cheque in its history. Menlo's stake was estimated to be worth nearly \$14 billion in June, according to a Bloomberg report. On the back of its Anthropic success, Menlo raised \$3 billion across two new funds in June this year, the largest corpus in its 50-year history. Anthropic is likely to seek a valuation of \$2 trillion in its upcoming IPO, according to multiple media reports – a figure that would sharply lift the value of Menlo's stake. Murphy, who joined Menlo in 2015 after more than 15 years as a general partner at Kleiner Perkins, declined to comment on the listing, citing the quiet period Anthropic entered after

confidentially filing its IPO papers. His comments on AI come amid an intensifying debate over AI safety. Anthropic CEO Dario Amodei called on the industry to slow frontier model development so that safety measures could catch up. On September 29, Amodei and other tech leaders signed a voluntary AI safety accord with President Donald Trump at the White House. For Murphy, the real issue is responsible release. "If that requires slowing releases down, like Mythos being pulled off the market, then so be it," he said. "It can't be the Wild West for

ever." He backed independent checks on new models. "If we get frameworks in place to gate the release of models, with third-party involvement in the eval process, then when something does go wrong, it'll be caught before things get too far along," he said. What limits the industry today, Murphy added, is the constraints on the compute capacity rather than frontier intelligence. Menlo's other AI bets include Suno, Lovable, Modal and work assistant Town. Menlo also seeded OpenRouter, which Stripe agreed to acquire in August for about \$7.5 billion.



"THE BEST OF TIMES & THE WORST OF TIMES" Menlo partner Venky Ganesan said the Anthropic bet came from spotting the trend before the company. "In investing, the most important thing is, what is the megatrend, and how do you jump on it?" he said. "When ChatGPT came out, it was very clear that the megatrend was going to be AI. Let's not hesitate, because if you get there early, you can find the winners." He told ET that the market today is pulling in two directions. "I think it is both the best of times and the worst of times

MATT MURPHY
Partner, Menlo Ventures

If we get frameworks in place to gate the release of models... when something does go wrong, it'll be caught before things get too far along

VENKY GANESAN
Partner, Menlo Ventures



In investing, the most important thing is, what is the megatrend, and how do you jump on it

for AI valuations," he said. "On one hand, we have companies growing at a pace we have never seen, going from zero to \$1 billion in revenue in 18 months. On the other hand, we have 3- to 5-person startups commanding valuations in the billions of dollars." According to Ganesan, position sizing will separate the winners.

INDIA'S INFLECTION POINT Ganesan, who has been with Menlo since 2013, said India is at an important inflection point and its AI future will depend on young founders, not IT giants. "So many of the big IT companies in India have been body shops... That's how they built their whole business and their identity, and that's not going to work," he said. "The future in India is not going to come from the large companies. It's going to come from young Indian entrepreneurs who are going to embrace being AI-native and take advantage of the incredible amount of information and technology available for them. They will find a way."

FOR FULL REPORT, GO TO www.economicstimes.com

VC & PE Investors Unlock ₹25k cr from Listed Firms in Sept Quarter

Stake sales in 18 new-age firms give SoftBank, Peak XV, Elevation & others a route to return capital

Nikhil Patwardhan

Bengaluru: India's listed startups are giving venture capital and private equity investors a continuing route to return money to their fund backers, with bulk stake sales yielding about ₹25,000 crore during July–September even as several investors retained sizeable holdings. An ET analysis of National Stock Exchange (NSE) and BSE block and bulk deal disclosures across 18 new-age companies shows sales by investors including Japan's SoftBank group and venture capital firms Peak XV Partners, Elevation Capital and Accel. To be sure, IPO proceeds are excluded from this total. SoftBank's Vision Fund-II realised about ₹4,538 crore from Lenskart and Meesho during the quarter, while Elevation's sales in Paytm and Meesho fetched about ₹3,013 crore. Bessemer Venture Partners took home about ₹170

crore from Urban Company. The liquidity comes amid record foreign selling in the broader market. ET reported on October 2, citing NSDL data, that foreign portfolio investors (FPIs) withdrew more than ₹3.05 lakh crore from the secondary market in January–September, surpassing all previous annual outflow records. The benchmark Nifty and Sensex indices were down about 14% and 15.5%, respectively, this year, amid higher bond

yields in the US, a stronger dollar and tensions in West Asia. For venture funds, the sales provide cash to distribute to limited partners, the institutions and other investors that finance them. Returning capital can support commitments to subsequent funds, while partial sales leave investors exposed to further growth.

Cashing out SoftBank, Peak XV, Elevation and other investors monetised holdings in July–September. The liquidity comes amid record foreign selling in the broader market. Source: NSE, BSE, company filings

"IPOs, block deals and secondaries now offer credible exits at scale," Nithin Kaimal, partner and India chief operating officer at Bessemer Venture Partners, told ET. Wider exit market IPO demand has held up despite the selling. Data firm Prime Database said that 78 mainboard IPOs raised a record ₹4,205 crore in April–September, up 35% from a year earlier.

FOR FULL REPORT, GO TO www.economicstimes.com

Investor	Stock sold in July–Sept (in ₹ cr)	Companies sold
SoftBank (Vision Fund 2)	4,538	Lenskart, Meesho
Peak XV Partners	3,354	Groww, Meesho, Mamaearth, Go Digit
Elevation Capital	3,013	Paytm, Meesho
Alpha Wave	2,729	Lenskart, Pine Labs, Aye Finance
Y Combinator	2,405	Groww, Meesho
Accel	965	BlackBuck, Amaagi, Urban Co, Bluestone

Bhavish Aggarwal Pledges 4.32% of Ola Electric Stake for Rights Issue

Our Bureau

Bengaluru: Ola Electric promoter Bhavish Aggarwal has pledged a 4.32% stake in the company to fund the purchase of shares in its rights issue, the electric two-wheeler maker said in a regulatory filing on Sunday. "This pledge is solely to fund his subscription to the issue, and there are no other pledges to his securities currently; no shares are being sold," the company said, adding that Aggarwal would invest in the rights issue alongside other shareholders on the same terms. At the last closing stock price of ₹37.09 on the BSE, a 4.32% stake in Ola Electric is worth about ₹742 crore. Last week, Ola Electric's board approved a rights issue of partly paid-up equity shares to raise up to ₹1,000 crore. The board has yet to finalise key terms of the issue, including the total number of shares, issue price, timing and payment terms.

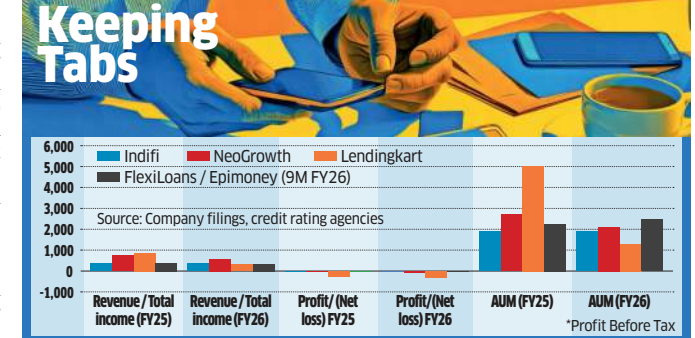
MSME Lenders Sacrifice Growth for Asset Quality in FY26 Credit Twist

Fintechs trim loan books, tighten underwriting to combat defaults

Ayanti Bera & Nikhil Patwardhan

Bengaluru: Fintech lenders focused on small business loans saw growth moderate in fiscal 2026, as they slowed disbursements and prioritised asset quality and cost discipline amid a challenging credit environment. The slowdown was mainly driven by stress among certain borrower segments, particularly those with high leverage, prompting lenders to tighten underwriting. Geopolitical uncertainty arising out of the West Asia conflict also weighed on lenders' risk appetite towards the end of the fiscal year. Revenue and loan book were broadly flat for Indifi, while assets under management (AUM) declined 21.5% for NeoGrowth and 74% for Lendingkart. AUM grew only 10%

for FlexiLoans' lending entity, Epimoney, in the first nine months of the year. WeRize and Procap bucked the trend, helped by business models that extend beyond pure balance-sheet lending. The pullback came even as the broader micro, small and medium enterprise (MSME) credit market continued to expand. A report by CRIF High Mark, a credit bureau, in June showed MSME credit outstanding around ₹46 lakh crore as of April–end 2026, up 12.8% from a year earlier.



FOR FULL REPORT, GO TO www.economicstimes.com

'AI Compute Needs Bankable Deals, Clear Exit Rules'

Industry seeks long-term contracts, tax deferrals & aircraft-style lender exit rules to scale AI compute

Suraksha P

Bengaluru: India's AI infrastructure build-out needs long-term demand commitments, easier financing and a clear exit framework for lenders and lessors, apart from tax relief on imported GPUs, industry executives said. They highlighted these demands at a closed-door meeting on 'Financing



India's Frontier & Compute Ecosystem' convened in Delhi by the India-AI Mission. "The fundamental challenge in financing AI compute is not the availability of capital, but the availability of bankable long-term contracts," said Sunil Gupta, chief executive of Yotta Data Services who attended the meeting. Yotta, which was officially empanelled under the India-AI Mission in February last year, has

committed to contributing more than 50% of the mission's total GPU computing capacity. The government should create credible four- to five-year demand commitments from government departments, research institutions and strategic AI programmes at commercially sustainable prices, he said. Such commitments would enable private operators to raise equity and assume technology, execution and operating risks, while banks, development finance institutions and global investors could finance the underlying infrastructure. Gupta suggested that the proposed National Frontier AI & Compute Fund should function as a catalyst through credit enhancement

Industry Wishlist Industry wants govt to create four- to five-year demand commitments at commercially sustainable prices

Need a single 'lender exit clause' covering customs, foreign exchange rules, banking regulations and secured lending laws

Humans Need Humans More Than Ever: Match Group Boss on AI Rise

Firm bets big on India by tailoring apps for Gen Z's demand for deeper connections: CEO

Surabhi Agarwal

THE FINE LINE Intentional dating apps are kind of blurring, kind of encroaching upon love-marriage apps

New Delhi: AI should bring two people closer, not stand between them, Spencer Rascoff, chief executive of Match Group, the Nasdaq-listed, \$3.5-billion parent of Tinder, Hinge, Match and OkCupid, told ET in an exclusive virtual interview. Rascoff said that for now, relationships between humans and AI agents remain a very small issue. But he does not dismiss the broader question of what AI could do to people's relationships with each other. "Humans need humans now more than ever," he argued.

The comments come as Match Group grapples with "swipe fatigue" and the emerging prospect of AI becoming a companion itself. Rascoff, who took over in February 2025 after co-founding real estate marketplace Zillow, travel booking site Hotwire and second-home platform Pacaso, jokes that he has gone from helping people "find a house" to helping them "find a spouse". He said that when he joined, he felt Match group's best days were behind it and is now trying to revive growth by rethinking how its apps drive connections, broadening the portfolio and adapting to Gen Z's idea of dating.

"When I joined Match Group, I felt like we had sort of lost our way," he said. "Hinge was growing rapidly, but Tinder and Match.com seemed to have the best days behind them." Even though Tinder remains the most downloaded dating app, monthly active users have shown some slowdown. The company says the decline is beginning to reverse and recommendation changes, features such as Double Date, Modes, Events etc, have improved engagement. Spenser said that he is pushing for more consumer research and spent time in focus groups with Gen Z users across markets. "They don't want to choose," he said, describing young users who may want romance, friendship or simply to meet new people without deciding upfront what kind of relationship they are looking for.

This matters for the company and India is an important test of whether that approach can translate into growth. "It is undoubtedly our largest potential market in terms of future growth". India already has a large user base on dating apps. Hinge alone had more than 1 million monthly active users in India in 2025. But the country contributes far less revenue relative to its scale. Rascoff said Match Group needs to take responsibility for closing that gap. "There's really nothing socially that needs to change. It's really on us," he said.

The company's research with global research firm Ipsos found that 72% of young singles in India prefer fewer but deeper connections, while 67% are seeking a romantic relationship. Of those looking for romance, 69% are seeking a serious relationship or marriage. That is blurring the line between dating and matrimony, Rascoff said, as dating apps increasingly cater to people looking for serious relationships. "There's a fine line there," he said. "Intentional dating apps are kind of blurring, kind of encroaching upon love-marriage apps." We need to do a much better job of understanding the Indian consumer and building bespoke features that Indian daters need and deserve, he added.

Trust plays a major part in that. "Trust and safety is incredibly important in India," he noted. "If we can make dating apps credibly safer than going to a bar or restaurant and meeting somebody, that's a massive opportunity."

Late last month, Hinge, one of Match Group's main portfolio apps, stepped up its India push with a more safety- and privacy-focused dating experience, including Face Check, which uses a video selfie to verify a user and match them with their profile. It has also added features to block profile screenshots and allow users to block people in their contacts. India is also the first market where Hinge is testing a phased waitlist for some new users to improve community quality. The move signals a bigger bet on India, already one of Hinge's largest markets globally.

Safety is one of several areas where Match Group is using AI, alongside photographs, profiles and recommendations. Rascoff said its recommendation systems are becoming more responsive to what users actually do on the apps, rather than relying on the app when they sign up. (Tanya Pandey contributed to this article.)

SPENCER RASCOFF
CEO, Match Group

It is undoubtedly our largest potential market in terms of future growth. India already has a large user base on dating apps



S Korea Orders Security Checks after Fin-sector Data Breaches

South Korean regulators urged financial institutions to promptly complete internal security inspections and report the results to authorities after a series of cyberattacks led to personal data breaches across the industry. "The entire financial sector should carry out swift and thorough security inspections," Financial Services Commission Chairman Lee Eog-weon said in a statement Sunday after holding an emergency meeting. – Bloomberg

enhancement or backstop guarantees, rather than simply financing GPU purchases or offering capital subsidies. "If we de-risk the cash flows and create bankable contracts, I believe capital for building AI compute infrastructure in India will follow," he said. Pyush Somani, chairman and managing director of ESDS Software Solution, listed GST deferral on imported GPUs as a necessity. Indian AI cloud providers currently pay 18% IGST upfront on GPU imports, blocking substantial working capital before the infrastructure begins generating revenue, he said.

FOR FULL REPORT, GO TO www.economicstimes.com



Next-gen GST: Taking Forward a New Phase of Growth for India

Next-gen GST was conceived with two connected purposes – to reduce and rationalise rates, and ease compliance. GST's growing maturity gives us a stronger foundation for the next stage of reform. This will come up before the GST Council shortly, writes finance minister **Nirmala Sitharaman**. **>> 12**

REFORMS & LIBERALISATION

India will Sustain Growth of 7% or More: Panagariya

India's growth is maintaining its momentum, 16th Finance Commission chairman Arvind Panagariya tells **Deepshikha Sikarwar** & **Kirtika Suneja**. He outlined several strategies to boost growth, including deeper trade liberalisation and more privatisation. **>> 12**

Reliance Retail Ends Partnership with 7-Eleven, Closing India Stores

Reliance Retail and 7-Eleven are ending their five-year franchisee partnership in India, closing most of their nearly 60 convenience stores after struggling to make the format profitable, reports **Sagar Malviya**. 7-Eleven may look for another Indian partner, although no decision is said to have been taken. **>> 10**

RIGHTS ISSUE SUBSCRIPTION

Bhavish Pledges 4.3% of Ola Electric for Raise

Ola Electric promoter Bhavish Aggarwal has pledged 4.32% in the company to fund the purchase of shares in its rights issue, the electric two-wheeler maker said in a regulatory filing on Sunday. There are no other pledges to his securities currently. **>> FACING PAGE**

FPIs Maintain India Connect with \$1 Billion in IPO Bets

MARKETS: BEATING VOLATILITY **>> 7**

ITAT DECISION ON IRISH CO BRINGS HOPE AFTER SUPREME COURT RULING ON TIGER GLOBAL >> PAGE 11

Automakers Bullish on Compact Hybrids

BRANDS: CREATING DESIRE **>> 10**



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COUNCIL MEETS ON WEDNESDAY

GST 2.0 Set to Amplify Ease, Unlock Tax Credit

New-look regime likely to push decriminalisation, rationalise provisions

Deepshikha Sikarwar

New Delhi: India is eyeing a broad overhaul of the goods and services tax (GST) regime that could free up thousands of crores of accumulated input tax credit, ease compliance and raise thresholds for prosecution, with emphasis on decriminalisation.

A host of such proposals, which include rationalisation of provisions governing e-way bill requirements and removing powers to arrest under the GST law, will be taken up by the GST Council at its meeting on Wednesday. The proposals span all touchpoints for a taxpayer — from registration, returns and refunds to input tax credit and litigation — marking a shift from procedure-heavy compli-

GST 2.0: The Conclusion

No arrest powers for tax officials

BOOSTING INVESTMENT

Tax paid on plants, machinery to be refunded over 5 yrs

WIDER AMBIT

Credit available on insurance for employees, vehicles & running cost

Telecom towers, pipelines included

SMALL BUSINESSES

Supplying only to consumer: To pay tax quarterly, file annually

Small refund balances written off earlier can be claimed

No notice to cases <₹10,000

This also covers pending cases

EXPORTS

Goods sold through overseas branch counted as exports

Work done in India on foreign client's goods counted as exports

Refunds regime streamlined: 90% claim released on risk check

Ease of Doing Business >> 5

ce towards automated, data-driven and risk-based administration, people familiar with the matter told ET.

"Safeguards imposed in the early years of GST can be relaxed without weakening enforcement because of the av-

ailability of data and advancement of systems," one of them said.

These process reforms would complete the GST 2.0 makeover.

RBI Likely to Hike Rates by 25 bps

Out of 21 economists polled, only one sees status quo

Rozebud Gonsalves & Atmadip Ray

Mumbai | Kolkata: The Reserve Bank of India monetary policy committee (MPC) is likely to increase the key interest rate by 25 basis points to 5.50% in the October policy amid inflationary pressures due to rising oil prices because of the West Asia conflict and farm output taking a hit on account of the patchy monsoon, according to a poll of economists conducted by ET. The rate-setting committee will begin its meeting on Monday and announce its decisions on October 7. Out of the 21 economists and bank ex-

ecutives that ET polled, 20 expect the RBI to hike rates, a reversal of their expectations ahead of the previous MPC meeting on August 3-5. One expects the rate to remain unchanged as it has been since December last year, when the central bank cut the rate by 25 bps to 5.25%.

Persistent high crude oil prices above \$100 per barrel have heightened inflation concerns, while the US Federal Reserve's rate hike last month will make it increasingly difficult for the Indian central bank to maintain the status quo, economists said.

ET POLL

Inflationary Pressures >> 5

Upward Path

RBI PROJECTIONS IN POLICY MEETINGS

Figs in %	Inflation		GDP	
	July	Aug	July	Aug
Q2	5.1	4.7	6.3	6.4
Q3	5.9	5.9	6.5	6.5
Q4	5.4	5.5	6.8	6.8
FY27	5.1	5.0	6.6	6.7



High Altitude



5% decline in domestic flights for Oct-Dec

1.2% fall in domestic seat capacity

68% higher fares for Delhi-Hyderabad

51% rise in Mumbai-Kolkata fares

₹137/litre current domestic ATF price

30-40% Jet fuel share in airline operating costs

Departure Options >> 5

URBAN DEMAND LOSING STEAM

Brands Focus on Small Cities

Consumer firms are banking on tier II-III cities this festive season, as demand in metros remains under stress. **Ratna Bhushan** reports. **>> 10**

PURE POLITICS

Keralam Orders Vigilance Probe Against CEC

The Congress-led UDF government in Keralam has ordered a Vigilance and Anti-Corruption Bureau investigation into allegations against Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar relating to his tenure as the state's PWD secretary in 2006. **>> 3**

US a Lonelier Power by Will: Jaishankar

External affairs minister S Jaishankar said the US had "deliberately become a lonelier power," putting Washington's changing posture and China's rise as key features of the new global order. **Dipanjan Roy Chaudhury** reports. **>> 4**

BJP Names its Picks for Rajya Sabha Polls

BJP fielded party worker Dinesh Arya from Uttarakhand for optics to counter Mallikarjun Kharge's Dalit argument, and actor Koel Mallick (formerly of Trinamool Congress) from West Bengal, for the Rajya Sabha elections. **>> 4**



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MUSCAT NEVER RECEIVED A REQUEST FOR BACKGROUND CHECKS

Oman Wasn't Consulted on Attacker Pilot Hamam

Had debarred him from aviation sector due to his proximity to extremist materials

Dipanjn Roy Chaudhury

New Delhi: FlyDubai co-pilot Hamam al-Hammami, who tried to crash the Dubai-Tel Aviv flight and violently attacked pilot Smit Machchhar, had worked for a limited period as a trainee at an Omani airline and was debarred from the aviation sector due to his proximity to extremist materials. Muscat did not receive any requests from his future employers on his background while he was being recruited.

The individual (Hamam al-Hammami) worked for a limited period as a trainee at an Omani airline. However, when the Omani authorities identified, at an early stage, his interest in accessing extremist websites on the internet, he was prevented from working in the aviation sector; senior sources in the Omani government told ET. This subsequently led him to leave Oman, the sources informed.

The Omani authorities did not receive any requests from other countries to conduct background checks on him for employment purposes, the sources claimed. "Had such information been requested, Oman would have shared the information available on him, as it is doing now," according to one of the sources quoted above.

The individual is an Omani national, born in the UAE, whose mother is of Syrian origin. He spent a

Bibi says Capt Smit 'Hero of Entire World'; Invites him and PM to Israel's I-Day Event



DUBAI: Israel's PM Benjamin Netanyahu has called Indian pilot Smit Machchhar a "hero of the entire world" for foiling an alleged attempt by the co-pilot to crash an Israel-bound flight, as he spoke with him over the phone. A video clip of the call was shared on social media. During the call, Netanyahu also invited the pilot and Prime Minister Narendra Modi to light a flame on Israeli Independence Day. "It's usually reserved for Israeli citizens, but I think here in this case, all the citizens of Israel will embrace you. So we hope to see you very soon in Israel." — PTI

OMANI AUTHORITIES BANNED HAMAM 'AT EARLY STAGE' When Omani authorities identified, at an early stage, his interest in accessing extremist websites, he was prevented from working in the aviation sector, senior sources in Oman govt told ET

significant part of his life outside Oman, both during his father's period of employment in the UAE and while staying with his mother in Syria, as well as during his studies abroad, sources pointed out.

It is publicly known that under the aviation agreement between Israel and the UAE, flights on route between the two countries may only be operated by pilots holding the UAE nationality or the nationality of another country that has normalised relations with Israel. It is therefore possible that this individual may hold another nationality, according to the persons familiar with the issue.

AUSTRALIAN CONNECTION

Meanwhile, Australian investigative agencies are probing the links between the country and Hamam al-Hammami. He was reportedly issued a student visa by Australia in 2014, and studied there between 2015 and 2017.

United Arab Emirates attorney general Hamad Saif Al Shamsi said on Saturday that the FlyDubai co-pilot had attempted to carry out a terrorist act and that he began executing his plan during the flight by assaulting the pilot inside the cockpit using a crash axe and attempted to seize control of the aircraft's controls, according to the UAE's official news agency WAM.

OTHER NEWS OF THE DAY

Rohini Court Lawyers to Strike Today

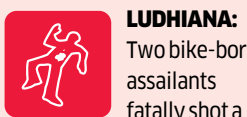


NEW DELHI:

Rohini Court Bar Association has called for a

complete abstention from judicial work at the district court complex on Monday to protest against the alleged manhandling and physical assault of an advocate at a police station. It said no police official of any district will be allowed to enter the court premises. A notice dated October 3, and signed by bar president Rajiv Tehran and honorary secretary Pardeep Khatri, said advocate Kamal-deep was "manhandled and assaulted" at Mahendra Park police station on Sept 29. — PTI

Ex-Sarpanch Shot Dead in Ludhiana Dist



LUDHIANA:

Two bike-borne assailants fatally shot a

55-year-old former sarpanch of Manneval village in the Ladhawal area of Ludhiana district, allegedly over a land dispute between two families, police said on Sunday. Navjeet Singh Neetu was driving towards his home in Ghumar Mandi when the attack took place on Saturday evening, they said. According to police, the bike-borne attackers intercepted his car and opened indiscriminate fire, killing Neetu on the spot, before fleeing. Seven to eight rounds were fired from a .30 bore weapon, police said. — PTI

Poliloquy R PRASAD



BJP WORKERS FILING OBJECTIONS DURING SIR UNDER POLICE LENS

BJP Warns of Agitation over FIRs on Form-7 Filings

Our Political Bureau

Bengaluru: BJP on Sunday warned of statewide protests if police register FIRs against its workers over Form-7 objections filed during the ongoing special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls.

State BJP president BY Vijayendra said the party had written to the police, urging them not to act against workers involved in filing objections. He said any issues arising from Form-7 applications should be dealt with under the Representation of the People Act, 1950, and not through police action.

The warning comes after police registered FIRs against several individuals, including BJP workers, for allegedly submitting bulk Form-7 applications seeking deletion of voters' names from the electoral rolls.

Chief minister DK Shivakumar has accused the BJP of attempting



THE RIGHT APPROACH

Any issues arising from Form-7 applications should be dealt with under the Representation of the People Act, 1950, and not through police action, says BY Vijayendra

to delete the names of voters belonging to the OBC, Dalit and minority communities. Rejecting the charge, Vijayendra said filing objections through Form-7 was a right available under the Election Commission's electoral roll revision process and alleged that the Congress was trying to intimidate BJP workers.

He said the party would launch protests across the state if workers were harassed or cases were filed

against them in connection with Form-7 objections. BJP has demanded that all such complaints be handled strictly in accordance with electoral laws.

Questioning Shivakumar's claim that 50-60 lakh voter names were being deleted in Karnataka, Vijayendra cited Election Commission data showing about 84,900 Form-7 objections and accused the Congress of spreading a misleading narrative for political purposes.

PROTECTED REGION IS FAST EMERGING AS A SECOND HOME FOR ASIATIC LIONS

Maldharis to be Moved Out of Barda Sanctuary

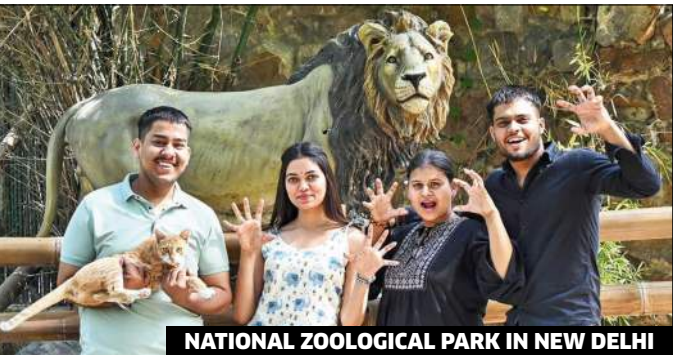
17 Asiatic lions, including breeding adults & cubs, have settled in Barda

DP Bhattacharya

Gandhinagar: With the Barda Wildlife Sanctuary fast emerging as a second home for Asiatic lions, the Gujarat government has announced a scheme to relocate the Maldhari (livestock guardian) families from the protected forested and hilly region.

Following the National Tiger Conservation Authority rules, the scheme offers families a one-time payment of Rs15 lakh if they choose to move out of the sanctuary.

Under the scheme, a 100-square-yard housing plot will be allotted



NATIONAL ZOOLOGICAL PARK IN NEW DELHI

free of cost to each relocating family, subject to applicable rules. The collector or district-level committee may provide this land near any village outside the boundaries of the sanctuary and its eco-sensitive zone. The plot must be located at least 10 km from the limits of a municipal corporation and 5 km from the limits of a municipality.

Furthermore, an additional plot of up to 100 square yards may be provided for livestock purposes based on their requirements. The market value of this livestock plot will be deducted from the ₹15 lakh assistance package, and the remaining balance will be paid to the family. The Barda Wildlife Sanctuary spans 192.31 square kilometres across Gujarat's Porbandar and Jamnagar districts. It has been developed under Project Lion as the official second home and western satellite refuge for the Asiatic lion. This initiative aims to reduce pressure on the Gir National Park and Wildlife Sanctuary, which has witnessed a significant increase in its lion population over the past few years.

Currently, 17 Asiatic lions, including breeding adults and cubs, have settled in Barda, which is also home to roughly 25 Indian leopards, striped hyenas, wolves and more than 150 species of birds. The Gujarat government has constituted a state-level committee to oversee the implementation of the scheme.

Against them in connection with Form-7 objections. BJP has demanded that all such complaints be handled strictly in accordance with electoral laws.

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GYANESH KUMAR WAS STATE'S PWD SECRETARY IN 2006

Keralam to Re-probe Role of Gyanesh in 2006 Case

Investigation pertains to suicide of a Malaysian engineer; a preliminary inquiry had then cleared Gyanesh Kumar

Our Political Bureau

New Delhi: Home minister of Kerala's Congress-led UDF government, Ramesh Chennithala, has ordered a vigilance inquiry against chief election commissioner Gyanesh Kumar dating back to his tenure as the state PWD secretary way back in 2006.

The probe pertains to a 2006 suicide of a Malaysian civil engineer Lee See Been, associated with a consortium tasked with upgrading the MC Road, and his "suicide note" allegedly naming Kumar for the latter's conduct as the then state PWD secretary. A preliminary inquiry had then cleared Kumar, who since then held various posts under the subsequent state governments before moving to the Centre and then becoming CEC. The Opposition Left welcomed the probe against Kumar but alleged that the previous UDF government had helped him come out of the old case.

Chennithala told journalists in Thiruvananthapuram that the vigilance probe was initiated after he received a petition from a local Congress functionary. He stressed that the legal immunity the CEC enjoys does not cover Kumar's stint as the then PWD secretary.

"A Congress activist gave me a petition regarding the malpractices



PROTEST SITE IN NEW DELHI

'RELEASED WITHOUT HER PHONE AND BAG'

AISA Members Claim Neha Bora Picked up by Delhi Police, Released in Narela



NEW DELHI: AISA president Neha Bora was released at the Narela Industrial Area police station after being picked up during the organisation's protest march towards Jantar Mantar on Sunday, members claimed. She was released

without her phone and bag, they said, adding that a team of lawyers was being sent to the police station to assist Bora. Earlier, AISA members had claimed that Bora was picked up by the Delhi Police in a private vehicle

without an official number plate and taken to an unknown location. — PTI

and corrupt activities of Gyanesh Kumar when he was PWD secretary in Kerala. The representation reveals some serious issues and also about a Malaysian project engineer, Lee, committing suicide and how his suicide note had mentioned (the then) PWD secretary Gyanesh Kumar. I have forwarded it to the vigilance director to go into the details of the petition and take legal action to deliver justice."

Chennithala said: "This is not a political vendetta. SIR and other is-

ues are there. We are fighting against him. But this case is different. As a minister, it is my bounden duty to go into the details of the petition, and if there is a cognizable offence, it is my duty to send it to the vigilance director for further inquiry."

Meanwhile, CPI central secretariat member P Sandosh Kumar said, "I welcome the decision... There were several allegations against him. But the then UDF ministry was helping him, and he used his influence through his relationships with senior politicians."

BJP HITS OUT AT THACKERAY COUSINS

Maha Oppn Parties Hold Demonstrations Against CEC & EVM

Krishna Kumar

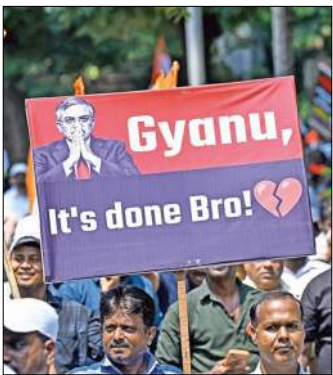
Mumbai: Maharashtra's Opposition parties joined hands on Sunday, demanding CEC Gyanesh Kumar's resignation, scrapping of the SIR exercise and going back to ballot papers. Congress, NCP-SP and Thackeray cousins — Uddhav Thackeray and Raj Thackeray — took out a march on Sunday in Mumbai, claiming that the Election Commission of India was going all out to help BJP win polls.

They claimed that ECI was systematically rigging the electoral process to help BJP come to power in Maharashtra and other states. The joint protest saw the Thackeray cousins march alongside the senior leaders of the Maha Vikas Aghadi (MVA) from Metro Cinema to the Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation headquarters.

"Voters should be deciding who should be in government, not the Election Commission, which is why they (government) are doing as they want. It does not matter if people are angry. They can protest, shout...we (read government) will destroy the economy, we will surrender to America, we will increase the price of petrol, foodgrain. They are not bothered about the people's reaction as they know that ECI will get them elected," said Raj.

Raj claimed that after BJP's disastrous performance in the 2024 Lok Sabha polls, 40-60 lakh voters were added in Maharashtra's electoral rolls and BJP won. He said that in the current SIR exercise, 2 crore voters were removed from the voters' list in Maharashtra, adding that the SIR exercise should be scrapped in the state.

Uddhav likened the Opposition to CEC to a "freedom struggle". "The government is using Gyanesh Kumar to remove voters from the list, claiming that they are Bangladeshis. We want to know how many of the 2 crore people removed from the Maharashtra voters' list are Bangladeshis and how did they end up coming into the state. Today, we have taken a step forward, tomorrow the people could raise their hands," he said.



Protesters in Mumbai on Sunday

The UBT president questioned why CEC was being protected and said that the people of the country "will soon decide his punishment". BJP leader Ashish Shelar countered by claiming that there were inconsistencies in the Opposition campaign. "Uddhav and Raj had a year back carried out a rally demanding the removal of duplicate names, as well as those who are dead from the voters' list. Raj himself wanted the names to be struck off the list. So then, why are you now opposing the SIR exercise?"

On reports that there were differences between CEC and the other two ECs, Shelar said, "In a democracy there are different views on issues,

but then things are decided with unanimity." He said the BJP government at the Centre didn't bring EVMs.

"While Gyanesh Kumar is being blamed for the Opposition's loss in Maharashtra, the truth is he was appointed after BJP came to power in the state. Out of six elections that have taken place in the country since he took over, three have been won by BJP and three by non-BJP governments," said Shelar.



A PROTESTER IN NEW DELHI

CRIME BRANCH TO LAUNCH PROBE

3 Journalists Allege Sexual Harassment by Delhi Police During Protest

Press Council of India expresses 'shock', demands immediate action

PTI

New Delhi: Three women journalists have alleged sexual harassment by police personnel during a protest against CEC Gyanesh Kumar at Jantar Mantar on October 3, prompting the Delhi Police to transfer their complaints to the crime branch for an impartial inquiry, an officer said on Sunday.

On Saturday one of the women journalists told PTI that an assistant commissioner of police (ACP) sexually assaulted her. The officer said the New Delhi district police received complaints following the alleged incidents during the protest, when

police personnel were deployed to maintain law and order.

The Press Council of India expressed "shock" over the police's treatment of journalists covering the protest and urged the Delhi Police to act on the complaint immediately.



One of the women journalists told PTI that an ACP sexually assaulted her

Any Process Which Disenfranchises Millions Arbitrary: SC Judge Bhuyan

HYDERABAD: SC judge Ujjal Bhuyan on Sunday said any process which disenfranchises millions of citizens is intrinsically arbitrary and a negation of the constitutional order. No amount of "whataboutery" can justify it. Speaking at an event at the NALSAR University of Law here, he said the Constitution does not provide for two classes of citizens. — PTI



NEW DELHI

When Defence is the Best Form of Attack

Protest fever is rising; so is the attempt to bring it down at any cost. There may be various reasons for this rising temperature, but measures to manage it are limited — a few dos and don'ts, and some steps on the ground. Captain Machchhar's fight back is a reminder that victory is not attained through attack alone. It's merely one of the mechanisms available to mankind. What truly counts is 'one last push'.

History is replete with stories about attackers who were decisively defeated by strong defensive techniques — Patton Nagar is a prime example of this. For those who don't know about Patton Nagar, they can do some research on Company Quartermaster Havildar Abdul Hamid PVC. Yet, America has

strangely decided not to educate itself. With Trump at the helm, it appears even less achievable. After bombing Iran and failing to subdue it, the US has pulled out of Iraq. And the Don is hailing the exit. Can you beat that? Is the Don preparing for a similar pattern in Iran: Declare victory and fly away? Americans are particularly good at that. Remember Afghanistan?

The protest fever gripped the UNGA too when Bibi started addressing the assembly in New York. Since he couldn't do much else there, he limited himself to verbal volleys. Given his reputation, Bibi should have done more. After completing his speech, he could have at least staged a dharna at the podium and demonstrated against the protesters. He might have used banners and slogans to make his point.



But it seems that Bibi was caught off guard. He either received no warning or lacked 'actionable intelligence'.

Bibi's experience shows that planning is crucial, even for pro-

tests, as unplanned events may fail to achieve the desired results.

Pravir Kumar

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Sports World Play



(Clockwise from below) 1. Indian contingent at the closing ceremony; 2 to 4. Japanese artists at work; 5. Robotic arms with flags; 6. Qatar's Jassim Ali Kuwari with the Olympic Council of Asia flag

Sayonara, Nagoya

Asian Games 2026 come to a close with a dazzling light and musical show; come 2030, 'aap Qatar mein hai'

Philem Dipak Singh

A dazzling light and musical show, sprinkled with a vibrant display of Japan's culture and hospitality, brought the curtains down on the Aichi-Nagoya Asian Games as the host country pulled off a spectacular closing ceremony on Sunday. After more than two weeks of intense competition, which had produced more than 350 records, including at least 50 world records, the athletes of the 45 countries of Asia joined the festive atmosphere at the Mizuho Park Athletic Stadium to mark the end of the Games marred by logistical troubles and mismanagement in the build-up. The ceremony lasted 90 minutes.

India finished fourth on the medal table with 85 medals (21 gold, 27 silver, 37 bronze), 21 less than the last edition in Hangzhou, China.

China topped the table for the 12th consecutive edition, finishing

with 169 gold, 89 silver and 83 bronze for a total of 341 medals, their best haul at an overseas Asian Games. Hosts Japan ended second with 269 medals (83 gold, 95 silver and 91 bronze), followed by South Korea with 39 gold, 43 silver and 68 bronze.

Olympic Council of Asia President Sheikh Joaan Bin Hamad Al Thani declared the Games closed in the presence of Crown Prince and Crown Princess Akishino. The OCA flag was later handed over to a representative of the organising committee of the

FINAL MEDALS TALLY

#	COUNTRY	G	S	B	T
1.	China	169	89	83	341
2.	Japan	83	95	91	269
3.	South Korea	39	43	68	150
4.	India	21	27	37	85
5.	Uzbekistan	21	25	24	70

2030 Asian Games in Qatar: The section relating to OCA flag handover to Doha featured Qatar's Olympic and world champion Mutaz Bashim.

Led by trap shooter Neeru Dhandra, who had won two gold and one silver in the Games, the Indians also joined the festive atmosphere. Around 30 Indian athletes and officials, wearing white and blue kits, took part in the Athletes Parade, waving the tricolour. To express the closing ceremony's

Mohod, Kalkal Named 1st Winners of Jaspal Rana, Randhir Singh Awards

Nagoya: Archer Kulkum Mohod and wrestler Sujet Kalkal have been named the inaugural recipients of the Jaspal Rana Award and Raja Randhir Singh Award, respectively, by the Indian Olympic Association (IOA) for their outstanding performances at the Aichi-Nagoya Asian Games. The awards have been instituted by the IOA to honour the best female and male sports persons of the Games and commemorate the legacy of two stalwarts of Indian sport who died earlier this year. PTI

concept of 'One Asia', a hexagonal stage was placed at the centre of the stadium, and it was the highlight of the show. It was adorned with lanterns, a quintessential symbol of Japanese summer, during the grand finale.

OCA President Sheikh Joaan Bin Hamad Al Thani said the Aichi-Nagoya Asian Games have raised the bar for Asian sport.

"I now declared the Aichi-Nagoya Asian Games officially closed," Al Thani said.

"Tonight, as we lower the flag on Aichi-Nagoya 2026, we close these Games, but we raise the bar for Asian sport. The flame may be extinguished, but the hopes it has ignited will continue to burn brightly across our continent," he said.

He said the Asian Games in Japan will shape the next generation of Asian sport. "From the first competition to the very last, Asia's finest athletes captivated us with their performances. Over 350 records have been broken, including more than 50 world records. This is a record for our Asian Games."

At the opening ceremony on September 19, the diverse athletes from Asia were represented by multiple layers of rainbow-coloured hearts. For the closing ceremony, the empty space in the centre of the heart was beautifully filled with the emotions and sense of unity. The idea was to unite the athletes to serve as a catalyst for Asian nations to continue working together in a peaceful environment for many years to come. PTI

DJOKOVIC DEFEATS ZVEREV IN CHINA OPEN 'Can Still Defeat the Best Players in the World'

Beijing: Novak Djokovic rolled back the years to oust Alexander Zverev from the China Open on Sunday, beating the top seed 4-6, 6-4, 6-4 to set up a blockbuster semi-final with Daniil Medvedev. The 39-year-old Serbian electrified a packed crowd in Beijing, where he extended an astonishing winning streak to 32 matches and is a firm fan favourite. He told reporters such battles were "evidence to me that I can still beat the best players in the world on the biggest stage". Among the women, second-ranked Aryna Sabalenka was bundled out in the third round in straight sets by the Czech Republic's Nikola Bartunkova. AP

Departure Options

►► From Page 1

"The busiest day for domestic capacity this quarter is expected to be December 7, with 589,386 seats scheduled, below the 603,634 seats on last year's busiest day," said John Grant, chief analyst at OAG.

OAG's data show the divergence across markets. Mumbai-Jamnagar capacity has more than tripled to 102,520 seats from 32,452 a year earlier, while Delhi-Navi Mumbai capacity has risen to 142,600 from 8,158 as the new airport ramps up operations. Ahmedabad-Kolkata capacity, however, is down 20.9% and Hyderabad-Jaipur by 33.1%.

That matters for passengers because fewer flights can mean fewer departure options on peak dates even when airlines maintain overall seats through larger aircraft. Where demand is strong and frequencies are limited, fares can rise faster.

Fuel is adding to the pressure. Domestic ATF prices rose Rs 16 a litre from October 1 to about Rs 137 a litre from Rs 121, following increases of

Rs 6.28 a litre in September and Rs 5 a litre in August. Fuel accounts for 30-40% of airline operating expenses, according to ICRA.

Domestic ATF prices were already about 20% higher year-on-year in August after oil marketing companies raised prices by Rs 5,000 a kilolitre, ICRA said. Airlines also have significant dollar-denominated costs, including aircraft leases and maintenance, leaving them exposed to movements in both fuel prices and the rupee.

"While traditional domestic favourites such as Goa continue to see healthy demand, with bookings up 10% year-on-year, destinations such as Leh, Dehradun and Amritsar are also seeing strong growth this festive season," said Aloke Bajpai, co-founder and group co-CEO of ixigo. "Higher ATF prices could put upward pressure on domestic airfares, particularly around peak-festive travel dates, while easier visa access and improving connectivity are giving international travel an added push."

Yatra said domestic fares are currently 30-

40% higher than last year, while international fares are 30-50% higher. Domestic bookings and searches have remained broadly steady, with strong demand on Delhi-Mumbai, Delhi-Bengaluru, Mumbai-Delhi and Mumbai-Bengaluru, as well as routes connecting major metros with Patna and Kochi.

Yatra expects fares on high demand routes to rise another 15-20% as departure dates approach, particularly where capacity remains constrained.

International schedules are expanding slightly faster, with flights up 3% and seats 2% year-on-year for the October-December quarter, according to OAG. Planned capacity to Saudi Arabia is up 22%, while Thailand is down 8%. Capacity to Canada has risen 27%, while planned capacity to China has quadrupled.

Demand is also shifting toward overseas leisure destinations. Ixigo's bookings to Hanoi have more than doubled year-on-year, while Bali bookings are up 89%, followed by Colombo (up 76%) and Bangkok (up 74%). Abu Dhabi bookings have risen 38% and Singapore 12%.

Yatra said international searches and bookings have softened from last year, although Southeast Asia and the West Asia continue to see strong demand.

Inflationary Pressures

►► From Page 1

"Following the dovish hold in August, we had deferred our base-case tightening call to 25 bps hikes in December 2026 and February 2027 (from October and December 2026 earlier). Developments since then point to an earlier start and more extended tightening cycle," Goldman Sachs said in a report.

The key repo rate was last raised in February 2023, up 25 bps to 6.50%.

Supply chain disruptions and elevated crude oil prices due to geopolitical tensions are at the root of current inflationary pressures, prompting even developed economies such as the US and Japan to raise rates. Domestically, economists see inflation rising above the RBI's tolerance level of 6% in the third quarter as the primary concern, driving expectations of a rate hike. The weather is another factor.

"I expect the Q2 and Q3 inflation numbers to surpass RBI's current projections because

se monsoons have been bad and crude oil prices have been higher than RBI's expectations. If geopolitics and crude prices continue the way they are, I expect Q3 inflation to peak at 6.2% to 6.3%," Canara Bank chief economist Madhavan Kutty G told ET.

Bank of Baroda chief economist Madan Sabnavis took a contrarian call on the policy rate.

"The current macroeconomic condition remains the same with similar kinds of risks as outlined in August. So why would RBI act differently this time? Besides, a rate hike now can dent festival spending while transmission would be sticky on the deposit side," he said, adding that deferring a rate hike would cool bond yields.

He however expects the repo rate to rise to 6% in this cycle as inflation is expected to climb.

IDFC First Bank expects December quarter inflation at 6.1%, while Bandhan AMC sees it at 6% plus.

RBI forecast inflation at 4.7% in the Sep-

tember quarter and 5.9% in the December quarter in its August policy. India's retail inflation was at 4.45% in July and 4.82% in August. The central bank targets 4% inflation with a tolerance band of 2% on either side.

Brent crude prices have risen sharply since August, when they averaged around \$91 per barrel. Prices crossed \$100 in early September and rose to around \$113 on September 9, amid heightened supply disruptions. Brent ended September around \$103, significantly higher than RBI's FY27 forecast of \$85 per barrel.

Two other factors strengthening expectations of a rate hike are stronger-than-expected economic growth and a narrowing interest rate differential between India and the US, which is making investments in developed markets more attractive. The India-US 10-year yield differential has narrowed to its lowest in decades, at 189 basis points, with yields at 7.21% and 5.32%, respectively.

"Growth has withstood the shocks of the West Asia war and there is more confidence now that the economy will be able to withstand a moderate tightening of policy rates," Yes Bank chief economist Indranil Pan said in a report on October 1.

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Ease of Doing Business

►► From Page 1

The revamp kicked off with last September's sweeping rate rationalisation, resetting the way the GST system interacts with businesses.

A key proposal on the table is in connection with easing input tax credit (ITC), which could provide an indirect stimulus to the industry by freeing up capital.

The council will consider allowing tax paid on plant and machinery and input services to be refunded in monthly instalments over five years, as businesses could not recover this under ITC, people cited earlier said.

The proposals also seek to widen credit for a range of business inputs that had previously remained blocked, including health and life insurance for employees, outdoor catering, telecommunications towers, pipelines outside factories, certain free samples and expired goods requiring destruction, vehicles seating up to 13 persons along with their insurance and maintenance, and leasing or hiring of vehicles.

"Unlocking blocked input tax credit under Section 17(5) can lower costs across industry and make Indian goods and services more competitive globally," said Bipin Sapra, partner at EY. "Also, refunding accumulated GST credit on inverted duty structures can turn locked-up working capital into growth capital, giving industry a capex stimulus comparable to a PLI scheme without creating a new subsidy."

The proposed credit on telecommunication towers and pipelines would address significant capital expenditure incurred by the telecom, refining, petrochemical, fertiliser, gas distribution and infrastructure sectors, people aware of the matter said.

A large number of goods in the 5% bracket, including food, pharma, textiles and electric vehicles, face inverted duty structure, leading to ITC accumulation running into thousands of crores. Releasing this stuck capital would prompt many industries to pump it back as capex, experts said.

Another key proposal is a change in the treatment of ITC when a supplier further up the chain defaults, leading to genuine buyers losing tax credit — an issue that has emerged as one of the largest causes of litigation under the GST system.

Under the proposed approach, a genuine buyer would be allowed to retain credit where the transaction is bona fide, while recovery would be directed at the supplier further up the chain who failed to pay the tax.

This is possible because the system can now identify mismatched or fraudulent credit closer to its source as seller and buyer data is linked invoice by invoice, said the people cited.

WHERE POLICY MEETS IGNITED MINDS



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Despite G7, Fuel Inflation Will Remain

Political move, economically underwhelming

Last week’s decision of G7, that grouping of 7 of the world’s most advanced industrial economies, to release 100 mn barrels of diesel and crude oil from emergency reserves is unlikely to put a lid on the fuel inflation they are grappling with. The draw down in reserves is a quarter of the 400 mn stock release coordinated by the International Energy Agency (IEA) in March. Around two-thirds of the initial commitment has been fulfilled. It’s not clear how much of the extra G7 promise overlaps contributions that remain from the March agreement. The pledge was extracted through Donald Trump’s threat of banning US diesel exports, which he says will not be needed after Europe gave in over its large diesel stockpile.

The G7 move is political with underwhelming economic consequences. Trump will be headed for midterm elections next month at a record low rating on account of high prices at US gas stations. He has unsuccessfully tried to pressure the Fed to go easy on interest rates. Europe is easier to convince because it’s now buying a lot of diesel from the US and an export ban will hurt. But that doesn’t translate into lowering fuel prices ahead of the midterms, or convince central bankers to go soft on interest rates amid a bond market selloff.

Total global crude oil production capacity is just about covering consumption. But supply disruptions and export restrictions over refined petroleum are throwing the market off equilibrium. Diesel export bans by Russia and China, and fouled up tanker movement, will add to the pressure ahead of winter heating demand in the northern hemisphere. Freight will remain expensive, adding to the inflationary impact of extended high crude oil prices. Trump’s unconventional moves over releasing diesel reserves will cause some dips. But underlying economic forces won’t pull energy prices off their perch. Correction is not expected till well into 2027 as inventories are rebuilt and shipping lanes normalise. Till then, threats of fuel export bans will serve to score political points at home and abroad.

Red Light Over Delhi’s ‘Green’ Crackers

Last week, Supreme Court gave firecrackers a reprieve from an absolute ban this festive season. Instead, it has opted to ‘balance’ popular and religious sentiment with the need to limit air pollution and protect public health. The top court ruled that specified ‘green’ firecrackers meeting prescribed norms can be used, but their use will be restricted to designated hours. The court is yet to finalise the timings, while the separate question of firecracker restrictions in Delhi-NCR remains pending. The order extends the relaxation nationwide and clears firecracker chains, or joined crackers (ladis), that remained banned under the 2025 rules.

The problem begins with the deceptively reassuring label ‘green’. These crackers are, at best, ‘less polluting’. CSIR-Neeri’s formulations cut emissions by 30-50%, while its latest Gen-2 formulations, with reduced barium salts, cut PM₁₀ and PM_{2.5} emissions by 45-60% versus conventional crackers. An improvement, but hardly a clean-air solution. For the Indo-Gangetic Plain, including Delhi-NCR, lower emissions per cracker do not make the aggregate pollution problem disappear. Nor is enforcement easy. Despite restrictions, conventional crackers flooded the market alongside ‘green’ products last year. Neeri says 1,403 manufacturers are registered, and green crackers carry product-specific QR codes for verification. But ensuring that compliant products are sold, and conventional or counterfeit crackers are not passed off as green, remains a challenge.

The court’s approach feels like one step forward, two steps back. A festive compromise cannot become a substitute for year-round measures that tackle the far larger sources of pollution. The thumb on the scale must favour cleaner air and stronger enforcement.



JUST IN JEST

The present Bengal CM has cast aspersions on the ex-CM’s leg in a cast

Can Didi’s Foot Note Turn into a Headline?

It turns out that if West Bengal CM Suwendu Adhikari’s contention sticks, former CM Mamata Banerjee’s contention that she had broken her foot, after being allegedly pushed by miscreants while on her 2021 election campaign, won’t have a leg to stand on. On Saturday, Adhikari reportedly produced a medical report that proves Didi’s claim to have been false. Now, claiming to have sustained an injury and making a show of it—she had subsequently campaigned from a wheelchair with her left leg in a cast—may not be a breach of electoral code of conduct. But coming as Adhikari’s claim does just before Nandigram town goes to the bypoll tomorrow—Suwendu-da defeated Didi in this constituency just a few months after leaving Trinamool for BJP—the bone of contention could be enough for voters not to trust the Mamata-backed Congress candidate (the Trinamool candidate literally decamped after meeting Adhikari). The state government has promised to launch a probe into Didi’s ‘false propaganda’, although it’s unclear what the consequences of such an old leg-pulling on her part can be.

If Adhikari is proved right, Banerjee won’t be the first or last person to fake an injury. Generations of schoolgoers have dodged duties by feigning a ‘stomach ache’, ‘dizziness’ or ‘bereavement of a (third?) grandparent’. Who knows? Didi’s foot note may make headlines yet.

RBI must look beyond the immediate gloss of GDP data and contain inflation amid external risks

Ok, It’s Time to Raise Rates

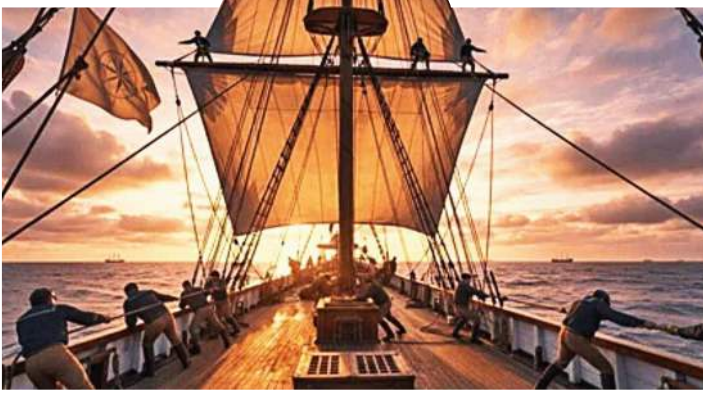


Mythili Bhusnurmath

All in all, the Indian economy has done exceptionally well, notwithstanding the multiple shocks it has faced. It is advancing ahead on a resilient growth equilibrium of 7%-plus, that is spatially broad-based, sectorally diversified, and underpinned by rising productivity, while steadily working to break into a 8%-plus equilibrium. This is quite a feat for a large emerging market, and makes India stand out in its asset class.

That was Poonam Gupta, RBI deputy governor in charge of monetary policy, speaking at the 13th State Bank of India Banking and Economics Conclave, less than a fortnight before MPC meets today to decide whether it’s time to take the punch bowl away. In the words of William McChesney Martin Jr, US Fed chairman from 1951 to 1970, the central bank’s job is like ‘the chaperone who has ordered the punch bowl removed just when the party was really warming up’. Martin holds the record as the chair with the longest tenure ever. We now know the reason why.

FCNR(B) has provided significant near-term room to manage external pressures. But it can’t be a permanent solution. In such a situation, it’s RBI’s job to voice caution



Unfurl pre-Diwali sail

He had his sights firmly set on the primary responsibility of the Fed: price stability.

In India, however, if there are any worries that inflation would play spoilsport, neither the deputy governor nor MPC, at its previous meeting, gave any sign of that. Unlike in the past, when worries on the macro-economic front were mostly on the external front, the punch bowl is still in play. GoI has taken the tab for higher international oil prices so that the pinch of higher prices in sectors like transport is noticeably absent.

It has also allowed RBI to buy time on the external front with its special FCNR(B) scheme that brought in dollars. Consequently, the fact that in the last 2 yrs, the capital account surplus has fallen short of CAD, resulting in a negative BoP of about \$5 bn in 2024-25 rising to touch \$23.6 bn in 2025-26, evoked almost no comment.

The net result—that ‘getting monetary policy right is RBI’s paramount responsibility’—seems to have been lost sight of. This, even though, by its own admission, India faced a tough situation. On trade, it had faced among the highest tariff rates the US had imposed on any partner country.

As a large net oil importer, it has been particularly exposed to the oil supply

disruptions in West Asia and price shocks. Agriculture is a significant part of the economy, and El Niño is a huge risk. The rainy season has ended with the summer monsoon rainfall during the June-Sept period recording a deficit of nearly 13%. Significantly, this is the 4th-lowest seasonal rainfall since 2001, and the 13th-lowest since 1901.

Yet, on the face of it, Gupta is right. The economy seems to be doing well, though financials couldn’t be worse. Oil prices are range-bound above the \$100-a-barrel mark, the rupee is weaker, the 10-yr yield is higher, and the surplus occasioned by RBI’s swap window might be keeping banks awake, but the hour of reckoning is yet to come. As far as the real economy is concerned, industrial production rose 8% in August against a 4.7% expansion recorded a year ago. None of this suggests an economy that might be in trouble a few months down the line.

It remained for finmin to express a contrary view. In its latest monthly review of performance for September 2026, the ministry said, ‘Festive

demand and higher input costs could add to near-term price pressures’, while warning that ‘geopolitical tensions and elevated crude oil prices could also add to imported inflation pressures’.

The fact is, India’s BoP pressures are likely to persist despite a surge in forex inflows through RBI’s special swap window, as seen by the weakening domestic currency, even as higher imports, and higher global interest rates and intensifying competition for foreign capital could strain the external account. RBI’s concessional forex swap programme has provided India with significant near-term room to manage external pressures. But it cannot be viewed as a permanent solution.

In such a situation, it is RBI’s job to voice caution. The US Fed, European Central Bank and Bank of Japan have raised rates in response, the first in response to a booming economy that, like the Indian economy, seems to defy logic, and the other two in response to a slowing one.

Many drivers of inflation—some good (strong growth) and some bad (energy supply disruptions, tariffs, deficits)—are beyond RBI’s control. But incremental increases in borrowing costs can help address supply-demand imbalances. Sure, central banks are never as effective in restraining supply-induced inflation. Higher interest rates will not reopen a blocked strait, replace a sanctioned supplier or mend a trade relationship. But they will, at the very least, restrain second-round effects

But they will, at the very least, restrain second-round effects. And, most important of all, it will not be for want of central bank action. And that is what MPC needs to ensure when it starts its 3-day meeting today. It must raise rates.

ChatGPT SHAIRI OF THE DAY

A pilot and co-pilot, locked in up high,
Must mind what they say as the long hours crawl by.
For long hours together, through suspicion and bad weather,
So, as a passenger, it’s best you know how to fly!

INDIA CLIMBS NINE SPOTS ON TOURISM INDEX				
India rose nine places to reach 31st out of 110 economies in the World Economic Forum’s Travel & Tourism Development Index 2026. Only five countries made a bigger jump in rankings: Malaysia (now ranked 26th), Albania (53rd), Laos (75th), Qatar (47th) and Thailand (38th). The index was led by Japan, the USA, and Spain in the first three spots.				
Biggest gainers on WEF’s Travel & Tourism Development Index				
	2026 rank	2026 score (out of 7)	Rank increase since 2024	Score change since 2024 (%)
Malaysia	26	4.50	13↑	5.8
Albania	53	4.14	10↑	7.0
Laos	75	3.69	10↑	6.1
Qatar	47	4.23	10↑	6.0
Thailand	38	4.35	10↑	5.6
India	31	4.42	9↑	4.3
Philippines	57	4.08	8↑	5.5
Nepal	86	3.55	8↑	5.1

MEME’S THE WORD

DOMESTIC INSTITUTIONAL INVESTORS SEE WITHDRAWING FPIs OFF



PRIM, But Is It Proper?



Krishnan Ranganathan

In the nursery rhyme, the Grand Old Duke of York had 10,000 men. He marched them up to the top of the hill, and he marched them down again. Sebi has done much the same with minimum ticket for portfolio management services (PMS). In 2012, Sebi raised it to ₹25 lakh. In 2020, it doubled to ₹50 lakh. Now, through PRIM (Portfolio Managers’ Route for Investing in Mutual Funds), a new MF-only route, it’s back at ₹25 lakh, although for a tamer product.

The new rulebook lets managers buy IPOs and new debt issues, and lets discretionary managers put up to 10% of a client’s money into unlisted investment-grade bonds, with consent. It allows derivatives exposure of up to 1.25% of the portfolio, the first explicit leverage the rules have permitted. PRIM lets managers build portfolios from direct MF plans, ETFs and SIFs, with the fixed fee capped at 1% (performance fees are allowed) and no more than 25% in funds run by an affiliated fund house.

India’s model is the nightclub bouncer who checks the size of your wallet. The rest of the world mostly lets you in, reserves wealth tests for riskiest features, then watches the bartender. India has that tool too. Its accredited-investor route, widened the same day, gates angel funds, but new PMS rules don’t

use it for leverage or unlisted debt.

US has no legal minimum. Fidelity will run a managed portfolio for \$5,000, under a fiduciary duty at any size. Yet, in the early-2000s, separately managed accounts charged about 2.05% a year and largely disappointed. The hard line is on profit-sharing. Only clients with \$1.4 mn under management (or \$2.7 mn in net worth), roughly ₹13.4 cr, can be charged a performance fee, over 50× PRIM’s ticket.

Since 2023, Britain’s consumer duty lets FCA challenge a price for being poor value, not just misleading—faulting a restaurant for a ₹900 cup of coffee, not a misleading menu. The EU is adding similar value-for-money tests, and limits commissions that portfolio managers may keep.

Hong Kong gates products, not doors. Only individuals with HK\$8 mn (₹9.8 cr) portfolio qualify as ‘professional investors’ who can be offered products barred from retail sale, and even they get suitability checks on complex products. Equity accumulators, nicknamed ‘I kill you later’, caused losses after 2008, and protests outside Hong Kong’s Securities and Futures Commission (SFC) offices.

Since 2010, performance fees accrue only above the portfolio’s previous peak. So, managers are never paid twice for the same gains. Operating costs, excluding brokerage, are capped at 0.5%, upfront fees are banned, and mutual-fund holdings must be direct plans. Sebi even cut PRIM’s proposed fixed-fee cap from 2.5% to 1%.

Short of accredited-investor wealth, nothing offered a personally managed portfolio between the humble SIP and

the ₹50 lakh PMS. India now has a regulated middle rung.

The 1.25% limit adds room for long-short strategies, which, used well, carry less market risk than a long-only book. The worry is, who decides. Hong Kong puts complex products behind suitability checks. India’s main gate is a signature on a consent form. Add up a fixed fee of up to 1%, a performance fee on top, up to 0.5% in operating costs, and the underlying funds’ own charges. If the portfolio is mostly index funds, the client is paying a chauffeur to ride the bus. Once a performance fee kicks in, the stack can cost more than the regular plans many such investors hold today.

Over 10 yrs, over 70% of Indian active funds in every category trailed their benchmark. So, a manager of managers must beat the market after 2 sets of fees.

‘Investment grade’ did not save anyone at ILFS. Unlisted bonds are hard to sell and valued by models. A 2004 Journal of Financial Economics paper, ‘An econometric model of serial correlation and illiquidity in hedge fund returns’, found hard-to-sell assets making returns look smoother than they really are, hiding volatility. 10% in such paper, backed only by a consent form, is fine until the day you want your money back.

India’s code of conduct bars managers from putting their own interests first. What it lacks is a test of whether the price is worth paying, and disclosure alone is not enough. In a 2010 Review of Financial Studies paper, ‘Why Does the Law of One Price Fail?’, 4 S&P 500 index funds, identical in what they held but not in fees, were given to subjects. Even with fees made plain, over 80% still didn’t put everything in the cheapest.

That is why Britain now judges value for money, and Europe soon will. In India, a performance fee charged to a ₹25 lakh client, or 1% a year, to wrap an index fund, must be disclosed but is never judged.

Old Duke of York marched his men up the hill and down again. Sebi has made the descent safer. But it’s yet to make it cheaper.



Back to square one

The writer is former ED, Nomura India



Good, Bad And Ugly

NARAYANI GANESH

Normally, villains and criminals are portrayed in negative light—they are shown to be ugly, with a mean disposition, and their very appearance can make you dislike them. But, taking a cue from Shakespeare who said you can smile and smile and still be a villain, today’s villains—at least in movies and serials—are quite dapper, smartly turned out and good-looking too. Sometimes, the villain looks far more attractive than the hero, as evidenced in some popular K-dramas. Could it be that the realisation is dawning on us that ‘some people with great virtues are disagreeable, while others with great vices are delightful’—as François duc de La Rochefoucauld put it?

Do nice people have to be boring? Not necessarily. So what if they don’t swear, yell and scream; so what if they don’t fight, lie or cheat; a pleasant deportment is to be much appreciated, any which way one looks at it. Their stories might not be as spicy, interesting, nail-biting or hair-raising as those of a villain’s, but still, they do have an exalted place in the universe. A bad person is inclined to cause hurt to others; that in itself makes him difficult to like, howsoever handsome he may be. And a shabbily dressed, below-average looking good person who would not hurt any being, could turn out to be far more attractive. We are prone to get carried away by exterior attributes, but it is the light or darkness that resides within that really calls the shots.

Chat Room

Miracle May Not Unlock Twice

Appropos the news report, ‘Flydubai Capt was Attacked with Axe: UAE’ (Oct 4), the disclosure by UAE authorities highlights the extraordinary danger faced by the cockpit crew and the courage required to prevent a potentially catastrophic disaster. The actions of Capt Smit Machchhar, who confronted the threat despite being injured, deserve recognition. His conduct demonstrates how presence of mind and personal courage can make the difference between tragedy and survival. The incident also raises questions about airline recruitment, background verification, crew screening and cockpit security. A transparent investigation is necessary to establish how the Omani co-pilot banned from flying in Oman due to his extremist religious views was cleared for duty and assigned to such a sensitive route. Gregory Fernandes Mumbai

Plural Prevails, Singular Fails

This refers to ‘Chief Election Commissioner Kahaniyan’ by Indrajit Hazra (Oct 4). CEC must strive for unanimity in all decisions, and if CEC and ECs differ in opinion on any matter, it should be decided by the opinion of the majority. If CEC is considered a superior in the sense that his word is final, he would render the other ECs non-functional or ornamental. CEC’s view must not prevail without any record of dissent by other ECs. Thought may be given to drawing up rules of business to elaborate on the principle of unanimous functioning as stakes involved in India’s electoral process are just too high. Pradeep Kumar Surat

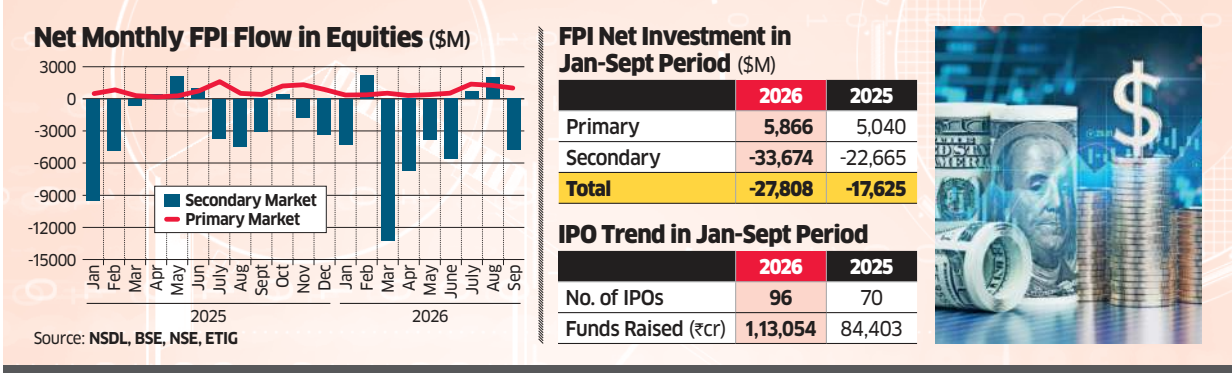
Stand at Ease, Attention

Appropos ‘Dive Into the Attention Economy’ by Punit Goenka (Oct 3), rightly, in the attention economy, success is measured not by the volume of content but by the attention it commands. But there is a troubling side to this race for attention. Reels, stories and endless feeds are creating a ‘monkey mind’—a restless and distracted mind constantly jumping from one reel to another. What begins as entertainment mostly ends in compulsive doomscrolling, mental fatigue and an uneasy emptiness. The question is not only how platforms capture attention, but whether they have a responsibility to not destroy our ability to sustain it. Gaurav Modak Mumbai

Letters to the editor may be addressed to editet@timesofindia.com

SEPTEMBER SHOW The flow of IPOs kept foreign investors interested in primary market even as they were sellers to the tune of \$4.8 billion in listed equities

FPIs Keep India Connect with \$1 billion in IPO Bets



Ranjit Shinde

ET Intelligence Group: The relentless flow of IPOs in September kept FPIs busy buying in the Indian primary market even as they accelerated selling in listed equities. They invested \$1 billion (₹9,676 crore) in the primary market while offloading \$4.8 billion (₹45,537 crore) worth of equities in the secondary market during the month, the highest since April 2026 when the outflow was \$6.7 billion (₹63,167 crore).

Of the 96 IPOs in 2026 so far, 34 were hosted in September alone. It implies that one out of every three IPOs this year so far was

crammed in a single month as IPO-bound companies scrambled to dodge the requirement of filing audited financials for the current fiscal year's recent quarters.

It also means the pace of primary market offerings may cool off in October since companies would take time to gather audited financial data for the June and subsequent quarters in the current fiscal year. Still, the expected launch of the Jio Platforms IPO in the second half of October may offer some support to the primary market investments given its anticipated size of over ₹35,000 crore-40,000 crore.

FPIs have invested \$5.9 billion in the primary market while selling \$33.7 billion

worth of equities in the secondary market in 2026 till the end of September. This compares with a net inflow of \$5 billion in the primary market and an outflow of \$22.7 billion from the secondary market in the corresponding period of the previous year. It means they continue to show interest in new equity papers while offloading their stakes in listed counters. Primary markets offer an opportunity to buy into businesses with strong growth potential, usually at a discount to the valuations of existing listed peers. Also, it does not involve the impact of bulk deals on stock prices as in the secondary market.

Large Caps Bear Brunt of Selloff

84% of Nifty 50 stocks below 200-DMA; Smaller stocks show some resilience

Ravindra Sonavane

Mumbai: The Indian stock market's latest selloff is increasingly becoming a large-cap story, with 84% of Nifty 50 stocks now trading below their 200-day moving averages (DMAs), while smaller stocks have shown greater resilience.

In the Nifty 50, 42 of the 50 stocks are below their 200-DMA. In the Nifty 500, 310 stocks, or 65%, are below the level, compared with 452 stocks, or 45%, in the broader BSE 1000.

The 200-day moving average (200-DMA),

calculated from the average closing price over the past 200 trading sessions, is widely regarded as a key indicator of the long term trend of an index or a stock. When a stock trades above it, the trend is considered positive, while when it falls below, it shows weakness.

"The divergence reflects the performance of different market segments over the past six months, with small- and micro-cap stocks seeing strong outperformance and mid caps also performing better than the Nifty," said Rohit Srivastava, founder of Indiacharts.

The pressure is visible among blue-chip

stocks. Tata Motors PV, Maruti Suzuki and Infosys are trading nearly 19% below their respective 200-DMA levels, while TCS is down around 18%. HUL, ITC and Jio Financial are each around 17% below their 200-DMA, while RIL, HDFC Life, Tata Consumer, ONGC, M&M and HDFC Bank are around 14% below the level.

Some of the weakness has spilled over into mid caps too but not as much in small- and micro-cap stocks, suggesting that selling remains concentrated in large caps.

Continued on >> Smart Investing

SMALLER EXPENSES WEIGH

Hidden Cost of Foreign Travel Can Add Up

Riju Mehta

When Siddhartha Kapoor and his wife decided to holiday in Thailand, in March this year, they budgeted a seemingly adequate ₹2 lakh for the eight-day trip. Yet, somehow, their budget ballooned to ₹3 lakh, a 50% rise. It's a miscalculation most travellers make while vacationing abroad, whether they plan a do-it-yourself trip or take a package tour. Focused on higher costs, they either forget or ignore the smaller expenses that they believe will somehow be taken care of.

Local transport, sightseeing and attraction tickets, visa fees, travel insurance, portage, city taxes, hotel security deposits, SIM charges or international roaming, airline seat selection

and mandatory charges, and tips in certain countries are among the costs that are often overlooked at the planning stage. If you, too, want a tighter control over your travel spending, consider these expenses.

For More Pick Up Today's Wealth

Airfare: In addition to the airport charges and platform booking fee, seat selection and excess baggage fee can increase the total fare. You could also face a surprise surge in fares due to currency fluctuations between the time you planned the vacation and when you bought the tickets.

Card costs: Your spending choice—credit card, forex card, cash—is important because the associated fees and charges are among the sneakiest add-ons to a travel budget. "On ₹2 lakh of overseas spending, a traveller can incur additional costs of 4-5% or more, depending on the card and how it is used," says Gagan Malhotra, COO, BookMyForex.com.

Continued on >> Smart Investing

GUV MALHOTRA HAS FLAGGED AI, DEBT AND CYBER RISKS

RBI Could Keep Rates Higher for Longer Amid Global and Local Risks

Factors including higher crude prices and US bond yields to shape central bank's policy response

Joel Rebello

Mumbai: Overseas developments could play a greater role in the Reserve Bank of India's monetary policy decisions as financial risks become more cross-border and interconnected, economists said.

Speaking to ET, economists said governor Sanjay Malhotra's speech at the Fifth Kautilya Economic Conclave, three days before the monetary policy decision, was a hawkish signal indicating that rates may remain higher for longer as global and domestic risks converge.

"In a way, the governor's speech is preparing the market for a higher-for-longer interest-rate environment than previously anticipated. The key driver of the RBI's policy reaction function is likely to be the steady tightening in global financial conditions," said Madhavi Arora, chief economist at Emkay Global Financial Services.

Arora said countries with a current account deficit such as India are facing challenges because higher US rates mean a significantly higher risk premium needs to be offered, particularly as global volatility and oil prices drive financial conditions.

Indeed, the gap between the 10-year US treasury yield has narrowed to 193 basis points from a recent peak of 273 basis points in March as the US bond yield has risen to a 24-year high.

In his speech on Saturday, Malhotra listed elevated global debt, stretched asset valuations linked to AI, higher leverage, defaults in private credit and cyber risks compounded by AI as emerging risks to global financial stability.

"The challenge before us is to build a financial system that can withstand the shocks we anticipate and those we cannot yet foresee. This requires resilient institutions, better data, deeper markets, credible safety nets, effective resolution mecha-



nisms and regulation and supervision that are proactive and forward-looking, while being proportionate," Malhotra said.

Economists said Malhotra's comments so close to the policy decision had put any doubts over a rate hike on Wednesday firmly to rest. With most of the risks stemming from overseas, global factors have also come to the forefront.

"Overseas factors are now more challenging with oil prices higher; US treasury yields up and generally market a little uncertain. On the domestic side, household debt is higher, credit growth is above the 10-year average and rupee remains under pressure. All these risks will play out into higher rates now with at least 50 to 75 basis point hikes priced in this cycle," said Indranil Pan, chief economist at Yes Bank.

Higher crude oil prices and lacklustre dollar inflows mean global financial conditions could increasingly dictate the course of domestic monetary policy, rather than domestic growth and inflation dynamics alone.

Brent crude has risen above \$100 a barrel this month on renewed US-Iran tensions after falling closer to \$70 a barrel in July.

"In the US, there is already a balance sheet expansion, a rate hike cycle and political pressure not to hike rates are playing out. These factors are all incongruous to each other and hence markets are manifesting in higher bond yields across developed markets, that are destined to go even higher," said Soumya Kanti Ghosh, group chief economic advisor, SBI.

Continued on >> Smart Investing

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DECISIVE TURNAROUND

Extract of the Un-Audited Standalone Financial Results for the Quarter and half year ended September 30, 2026

(₹ in Lakhs except per share data)

TOTAL REVENUE FROM OPERATIONS

17,206.37

vs 6,968.21 in Q2 FY 2025-26

PROFIT BEFORE TAX

7,401.08

vs (4,246.41) in Q2 FY 2025-26

NET PROFIT/ (LOSS)

5,536.71

vs (4,330.03) in Q2 FY 2025-26

S. N.	Particulars	STANDALONE					
		Sep 30, 2026 (Un-audited)	June 30, 2026 (Un-audited)	Sep 30, 2025 (Un-audited)	Half-Year Ended Sep 30, 2026 (Un-audited)	Half-Year Ended Sep 30, 2025 (Un-audited)	Year Ended March 31 2026 (Audited)
1.	Total income from operations	17,551.41	11,876.63	7,183.83	29,428.05	13,771.39	34,566.01
2.	Net Profit/(Loss) for the period/year (before tax and Exceptional items)	7,401.08	4,211.75	383.71	11,612.84	387.95	4,721.01
3.	Net Profit/(Loss) for the period/year before tax (after Exceptional items)	7,401.08	4,211.75	(4,246.41)	11,612.84	(4,242.17)	15.70
4.	Net Profit/(Loss) for the period/year after tax and Exceptional items	5,536.71	3,662.15	(4,330.03)	9,198.87	(4,347.89)	(787.40)
5.	Total Comprehensive Income for the period/year [Comprising Profit / (Loss) for the period/year (after tax) and Other Comprehensive Income (after tax)]	5,538.97	3,664.40	(4,328.63)	9,203.39	(4,345.07)	(778.85)
6.	Equity Share Capital	432.87	144.29	144.29	432.87	144.29	144.29
7.	Other Equity	50,923.57	45,804.42	38,573.80	50,923.57	38,573.80	42,140.02
8.	Earnings per share of Rs 2 each						
(a)	Basic (Rs)	25.58	16.92	(20.01)	42.50	(20.09)	(3.64)
(b)	Diluted (Rs)	25.58	16.92	(20.01)	42.50	(20.09)	(3.64)

Notes:

The above results were reviewed by the Audit Committee and approved by the Board of Directors at its meeting held on October 03, 2026.

The above is an extract of Un-audited Financial Results of the Company for the quarter and half-year ended 30.09.2026 filed with the Stock Exchange under Regulation 33 of the SEBI (Listing Obligations & Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015. The full format of the Un-Audited financial Results for the quarter and half-year ended 30.09.2026 are available on the Bombay Stock Exchange website www.bseindia.com and on the Company's website www.hindusthaninsulators.com

For Hindusthan Insulators & Industries Limited
Sd/-
DEEPAK KEJRIWAL
MANAGING DIRECTOR
DIN : 07442554

Place : Mandideep (M.P.)
Date : 03.10.2026

Hindusthan Insulators & Industries Limited

(Formerly known as Hindusthan Urban Infrastructure Limited)

(An Enterprise of The Hindusthan Group)

CIN: L31300DL1959PLC003141

Regd. Office: Kanchenjunga, 7th Floor, 18, Barakhamba Road, New Delhi - 110001

Phone: 011-23310001; Website: www.hindusthaninsulators.com; E-mail: investors@hindusthan.co.in

India could See Rebound in Investor Interest when AI-led Rally Slows

ET Q&A **SANKARAN NAREN**
ED & CIO, ICICI PRUDENTIAL MF

Investors looking to invest overseas should be conscious of the fact that they may be investing following a period of strong performance, said Sankaran Naren, executive director and CIO at ICICI Prudential Mutual Fund. In an interview with **Prashant Mahesh**, Naren spoke about domestic equities, earnings growth and the AI boom in the US, among other topics. Edited excerpts:

With lump-sum investors losing money and SIP investors making only low single-digit returns over the past two years, what should investors expect going forward?
We have been telling investors to focus on asset allocation, unconstrained investing, and expect moderate returns. The reason for moderate returns is precisely the current environment, where the US AI cycle is driving a large part of global markets, geopolitical risks remain elevated, and global equity markets are expensive. At some point, expensive markets will have to correct.

Do you still feel the market is expensive?
We are in middle territory. The sectors connected to US AI look overvalued unless you have a growth mindset. Small- and mid-cap stocks are not cheap largely because of the sustained flows into them. It is not

that such companies are not growing. They can certainly be growing, and some may even be growing faster than large-cap companies.

How are you looking at markets keeping in mind the continued boom in AI?
If AI-related growth continues to remain strong, Indian equity markets may continue to face pressure from shifting global preferences. However, when AI-led growth begins to slow, we believe India could see a rebound in investor interest as capital looks towards markets with stronger domestic growth prospects.

What is your assessment of the flood of IPOs?
We think IPOs are trading at higher prices than many of the older listed companies. There seems to be a bigger bull market in IPOs than in the broader market.

So where would you allocate and where would you stay away?
I like contrarian investing now be-

INSURANCE NORMS
Whenever regulations have become more customer-friendly, the industry has grown

DUMMY IN PLAY NHB doubts co may have in its books fictitious, non-genuine loan accounts NHB Set to Conduct Forensic Audit of SRG Housing Finance

Saloni Shukla

Mumbai: The National Housing Bank (NHB) has launched a forensic investigation into SRG Housing Finance to establish whether fictitious loans were created in its books, repayment entries were manipulated and the same loan assets were offered to more than one lender, people familiar with the matter said.

NHB issued a request for proposal (RFP) on October 3 to audit a non-deposit-taking housing finance company based in Udaipur. The tender does not name SRG, which is headquartered in the city, but people familiar with the matter identified it as the lender under scrutiny. NHB has yet to appoint an audit firm.

NHB wants the auditor to “identify and investigate fictitious, dummy, non-genuine or unsupported loan accounts appearing in the books” and establish whether the named borrowers exist. This will require checking customer identification records, sanctions, disbursements, bank accounts, loan documents, repayment trails and the use of funds. The shortlisted audit firm will investigate the company’s loan origination and accounting systems. Auditors have been asked to inspect access controls and electronic logs for the creation, deletion, alteration or backdating of loan accounts, customer records, EMI payments and non-performing asset classifications. They will also examine unusual user activity and system overrides. NHB and SRG Housing Finance did not respond to ET’s queries.

“The audit will establish whether the borrowers and loans are genuine, how the accounts and repayment entries were created or changed, and whether the same loans were offered as security to multiple lenders. It will also quantify the financial impact of any irregularities found,” said a person familiar with the matter. ET reported on September 10 that NHB had red-flagged its exposure to SRG after an earlier inquiry identified suspected fictitious loans worth ₹300-400 crore. The suspected accounts amounted to roughly a third of its reported loan book. SRG



had assets under management of ₹1,076 crore as of June, up 35% from a year earlier, according to its investor disclosures. The forensic audit will test the earlier findings. “The investigation will also examine whether the same borrower, security or receivable was pledged or otherwise represented to multiple lenders, and identify any fictitious accounts offered as security for NHB refinancing. Auditors must check whether stressed loans were

shown as standard assets to lenders and verify files for accounts in which earlier observations had flagged false EMI collection postings. NHB has sought an independent, loan-by-loan assessment of non-performing assets as of March 31, 2025, and March 31, 2026, including a review of overdue amounts, reversals, restructuring and subsequent recoveries. The auditor must quantify the financial impact of any irregularities identified. Bids close on October 13. The selected firm will have 10 working days to conduct the audit in Udaipur and another 10 working days to submit its report. In a September 10 stock exchange filing, SRG Housing Finance said an NHB inspection was underway as part of the regulator’s routine oversight. It denied the allegations, saying, “There has been no creation or maintenance of fictitious accounts by the company nor has any amount been diverted for any purpose.”

auditors have been asked to inspect access controls and electronic logs for the creation, deletion, alteration or backdating of loan accounts

Large Caps Bear Brunt

►► From ET Markets Page 1

Within the Nifty 500, 190-odd stocks are trading above their 200-DMA. Of these, 52 are 1-5% above the level, 28 are 5-10% above, 65 are 10-20% above, 21 are 20-30% above and 15 are more than 30% above their 200-DMA. The BSE 1000 presents a broader picture, with 542 stocks still trading above their 200-DMA. Of these, 97 are within 1-5% of the level, 114 are 5-10% away, 188 are 10-20% away, 100 are 20-30% away and 43 are more than 30% above their 200-DMA. “The correction is not impacting all segments equally, with large caps currently showing greater deterioration while parts of the mid- and smallcap space are holding their long-term trend better,” said Hitesh Tailor, technical research analyst at Choice Broking. “The gap between Nifty 500 and

BSE 1000 breadth points to market dispersion rather than uniform weakness,” said Tailor.

OVERSOLD
While a decline below 200 DMA points to a weak undertone, extreme readings are considered contrarian indicators. Analysts said the extent of fall in blue-chips is suggesting the selling is overdone. “The drop in Nifty is showing it is oversold as it was in March of 2020 or even in March of 2026 this year,” said Srivastava. “Such extreme readings in the Nifty have historically been associated with market bottoms.” Mid- and small-cap stocks are not yet there. “A similar condition across the Nifty 500 would point to broader market capitulation. But we have not seen capitulation across the board as of now,” he said.



cause of the significant gap between what has performed well and what has not. At this point, we like sectors such as private-sector banks and insurance, where growth is not a problem. We are also positive on insurance following the proposed regulatory changes announced recently. Our experience in the mutual fund industry has been that whenever regulations have become more customer-friendly, the industry has grown. That is why we see the changes in the insurance industry as a positive trigger from a longer-term perspective. But in sectors such as IT and FMCG, growth has been an issue. The challenge is that people always want either a very positive view or a very negative view. The reality is somewhere in between.

What kind of earnings growth do you expect over the next three

years?

Over the near term, earnings growth is likely to remain reasonably good. One reason is that inflation is positive for earnings. Second, when inflation is rising, consumers often advance their purchases. This brings demand forward. So, in the near term, earnings are likely to remain reasonably decent. In the medium term, however, earnings will depend on what happens to the US AI cycle. If the US AI cycle eventually leads to deflation, purchasing decisions could get postponed. Companies may reduce inventories, and consumers may defer purchases. That can have an impact on earnings growth.

How should investors approach gold and silver?

Investors need not be negative on gold at this point. We continue to like gold as a component of multi-asset investing.

There is a rush among investors to allocate money overseas to diversify

At this point, we would be cautious about making a momentum-driven decision to invest overseas. Both the currency and global equity markets have moved significantly. Investors should be conscious of the fact that they may be investing following a period of strong performance. The situation, however, is different with global bonds. Bonds have performed poorly globally, so investing in global fixed income today is less of a momentum decision.

LIKES & DISLIKES

we like sectors such as private banks and insurance, where growth is not a problem. But in sectors like IT and FMCG, growth has been an issue

Do you think FPIs will return to India soon, especially when US interest rates are at a two-decade high?

Right now, investors can earn around 5.3-5.5% in US Treasury instruments. They can also invest in US bonds and earn attractive yields without significant currency risk. For FPIs to return significantly to India, we will need an environment of lower global interest rates.

Our view is that we are not very far away from the peak in US interest rates. There could perhaps be two more hikes, but after that we do not believe the hiking cycle will continue indefinitely.

There is one major engine, i.e., the US AI cycle, which is driving a large part of the global investment environment. Emerging markets are not seeing significant inflows. It is not just India. This year, for example, money has gone out of markets such as Korea and Taiwan. Some money is going into Brazil and other countries, partly because they are large oil producers.

TECHNICAL VIEWS

Nifty Nears Key Support Zone, Raising Prospects of a Rebound

Nifty extended its losing streak to a record eighth consecutive week, moving closer to a crucial long-term support zone around 22,000-22,600. While the index remains under pressure, oversold conditions and support from long-term moving averages and trend lines have raised the possibility of a technical rebound.

ROHAN SHAH

SENIOR TECHNICAL ANALYST, ASIT C. MEHTA INVESTMENT INTERMEDIATES

Nifty Strategy: Nifty has moved closer to the crucial 22,000-22,200 support zone, which coincides with its 200-week EMA and the lower boundary of the multi-year consolidation range. Oversold momentum and breadth readings, coupled with historically favourable October seasonality, increase the probability of a recovery. Traders can buy Nifty Futures for an upside target of 23,000-23,300, with a

stop loss below 22,000.

TOP STOCKS FOR THE WEEK

Indian Hotel: Buy | **CMP:** ₹718 | **Target:** ₹800 | **Stop loss:** ₹678

The stock is consolidating above its 50-week EMA, with supportive volumes indicating potential for further upside.

Torrent Pharma: Sell | **CMP:** ₹4,767 | **Target:** ₹4,250 | **Stop loss:** ₹5,050

RSI remains in a declining trend and faces resistance around its moving average, while a downside range shift indicates weakening momentum and scope for profit-booking.

AJIT MISHRA

SVP-RESEARCH, RELIGARE BROKING

Nifty Strategy: Nifty tested key long-term moving-average support zone of 200-week SMA and 200-week EMA around 22,400-22,600, after nearly six years.

Traders can adopt a hedged approach, targeting 22,800 initially and then 23,100-23,200. A decisive break below the April low could negate the rebound and drag the index towards 21,700-22,000.

TOP STOCKS FOR THE WEEK
Mankind Pharma: Buy | **CMP:** ₹2,535 | **Target:**

₹2,680 | **Stop loss:**

₹2,410

The stock rebounded from ₹2,250-2,300 support, reclaimed short- and medium-term averages, and a decisive move above ₹2,600 would strengthen the trend, driving the stock towards ₹2,700.

IOC: Sell | **CMP:** ₹131.3 | **Target:** ₹119 | **Stop loss:** ₹137

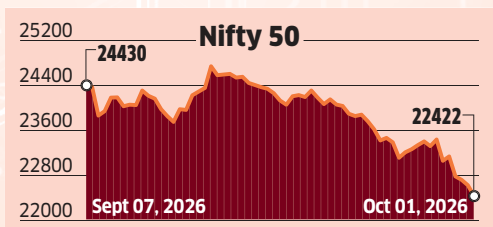
The stock remains under pressure, showing distribution after its fall from ₹180; repeated failures at the ₹140-145 zone and consolidation signal supply, with weakness below ₹130 exposing ₹124-119

PABITRO MUKHERJEE

DEPUTY VICE PRESIDENT, TECHNICAL, BAJAJ BROKING

Nifty Strategy: Nifty tested the rising trendline joining major lows of the last two years and 200-week EMA. The immediate bias remains down, and a follow-through weakness below the April low of 22,182 could extend the decline towards the CY25 low of 21,750.

However, oscillators on the weekly and daily



charts have reached extremely oversold territory after the sharp decline. Holding above the April 2026 low, which also coincides with key long-term support, could trigger a pullback towards 22,800 and

23,000. Traders can buy Nifty October Futures at current levels and on dips towards 22,400 for targets of 22,800 and 23,000, with a stop loss at 22,200.

TOP STOCKS FOR THE WEEK

HDFC Bank: Buy | **CMP:** ₹721.2 | **Target:** ₹775 | **Stop loss:** ₹690

Offers a fresh opportunity, with ₹775 being the confluence of falling trendline resistance and the 61.8% retracement of the previous decline from ₹843 to ₹682.

Cummins India: Buy | **CMP:** ₹4,860 | **Target:** ₹5,230 | **Stop loss:** ₹4,670
Expected to resume its upmove towards ₹5,230, the 38.2% retracement of the decline from ₹6,100 to ₹4,741.

RBI Could Keep Rates Higher

►► From ET Markets Page 1

“Together with these global factors, in India, in the second half of the fiscal, we will see higher inflation on the back of a weaker monsoon. With the dollar index set to strengthen further from current levels and capital outflows (\$4.5 billion in the last week already) with higher US yields, the rupee

will be under pressure,” said Ghosh of SBI.

From the RBI’s perspective, governor Malhotra would want to communicate the central bank’s forward path more clearly.

The speech on Saturday prepares the ground for a shift to more hawkish language.



“The last MPC minutes conveyed a distinctly different message from the actual policy action and came across as relatively hawkish. This time, the emphasis needs to be on consistent communication and preparing markets for what lies ahead,” Arora from Emkay said, adding that there remains an outside chance that the RBI may deliver a 50 basis point hike on Wednesday rather than the widely expected 25 basis points, as a form of policy catch-up.

Hidden Costs of Foreign Travel Can Add Up

►► From ET Markets Page 1

“A conventional credit card with a 3.5% forex markup would add ₹7,000, with 18% GST on the markup adding another ₹1,260, taking the additional cost to ₹8,260, or 4.13%, before considering the exchange rate used for conversion,” Malhotra says. **Visa & insurance:** While travel insurance may not be a huge cost, it is important to get one to avoid incurring large sums in case of a medical emergency, trip cancellation, lost luggage, delays, etc, which can send your travel budget haywire. Visa fees, on the other hand, can set you back by a few thousand rupees for destinations like Europe, the UK, the US, Australia and New Zealand. Don’t forget the ancillary visa costs, such

as the service centre fees, and documentation, picture and photocopying costs.

Local transport: Airport transfers, local cabs, and inter-city travel costs are typically ignored by travellers, but these can hike the total cost sharply. Public transport is the most affordable option for commuting, and overnight trains, as opposed to internal flights, are a good choice for inter-city travel, especially with discounts you get for booking in advance. Buying weekly or day passes can save a lot compared to single-ride tickets in countries like Japan, Thailand, Singapore, and Germany. **Food & drinks:** This category probably sees the most budget breaches, as bottled water is a necessity in most countries and food purchases can be impulsive.

The cost is much higher in Europe. “Be it casual dining or the occasional splurge, food can typically cost ₹15,000-25,000 per person for 2-3 days in Europe,” says Arihant Kothari, Category Head, Holiday Packages, Cleartrip. **Package tours:** If you take a package from a tour operator at the advertised headline price, you will invariably overshoot the budget due to exclusions. These can include mandatory city or hotel taxes, sightseeing tickets, optional excursions, airport transfers outside specific times, meals other than breakfast, hotel surcharges, and tipping, among others. “For a 7-10 day overseas trip, the final spend can vary by 20-30% compared with the advertised package price,” says Bharatt Malik, Senior Business Head, Yatra Online.

Tech Picks | **AAKASH K HINDOCHA**, Vice President - Research | **Nuvama Wealth Management**

DLF
Consolidating for past 12 weeks. A quick 7-8% rally northwards is likely to commence in this series.
BUY
TARGET ₹715
LAST CLOSE ₹658 **STOP LOSS** ₹642

ADANI GREEN
Stock likely to find buyers at the current support zone of 50% retracement.
BUY
TARGET ₹1,400
LAST CLOSE ₹1,276 **STOP LOSS** ₹1,212

PVR INOX
Looks ready for a fresh swing high on daily and weekly charts as the ongoing breakout continues to hold.
BUY
TARGET ₹1,330
LAST CLOSE ₹1,215 **STOP LOSS** ₹1,180

F&O Strategy

NIFTY OCT'26 FUTURE
Nifty has bounced off its 200 week EMA signaling an early reversal on charts.
BUY
TARGET ₹23,300
LAST CLOSE ₹22,500 **STOP LOSS** ₹22,250

IN THE GAME Co’s feat helps re-establish tech services’ commercial viability

Blockbuster Accenture Show Holds Out Hope for Battered Indian IT

Ashok Bhattacharjee

Mumbai: Accenture surged more than a fifth Thursday - a record for the global technology services leader and rare for a company with more than \$100 billion in market value. It holds out hope for Indian IT - still the Nifty’s third largest by weighting after financials and energy - and is a timely reminder to investors that they may have written the \$315-billion industry’s obituary rather prematurely.

Yet, it would be equally premature to assume Accenture’s standout FY26 performance and robust guidance for next year would trigger an immediate re-rating for India’s listed outsourcing pureplay.

Investor enthusiasm for Infosys and Wipro American Depository Receipts (ADRs), which climbed up to 8% on Oct 1, reflects scarcity premium rather than belief in an immediate sectoral turnaround, although some analysts believe the depressed valuations (table attached) adequately reflect the industry’s AI-spawned revenue risks.

Against this backdrop, Accenture’s earnings at least helped re-establish the industry’s commercial viability in the AI era.

Its healthy book-to-bill ratio shows that tech services companies have regained the ability to translate promises (orders) into reality (sales). Those harnessing AI to make a strategic difference to their clients should see their addressable universe expand - not shrink. Accenture’s last FY performance proved that even managed services engagements - or pure-play, cost-focused outsourcing, the mainstay of Indian IT - are becoming more value-loaded.

“Our managed services-led work also includes significant consulting and AI expertise, as many clients use this work to both reinvent and to get greater certainty around outcomes, including cost savings,” Accenture CEO Julie Sweet told analysts in the conference call after the earnings. “Against this backdrop, two things stand out. First, our largest client relations-

Valuation Reset

IT stock YTD returns (%)	
TCS	-36
Infosys	-37
HCL Tech	-24
Wipro	-40
Tech Mahindra	-4

hips continue to expand as clients take on broader, more strategic transformations. The second stand-out is how our AI demand is broadening because of both the depth and breadth of our expertise.”

AI-ERA EXPERTISE

The key for Indian IT to extract a re-rating from analysts, following this year’s 14% retreat in the Nifty IT index, is to help expand this ‘depth and breadth of expertise’ - something Accenture harnessed for 141 quarterly client bookings exceeding \$100 million each. Separately, stable and improving margins close to 16% indicate moderation in pricing pressures, while a 6% revenue guidance - matching the highest in four years - suggests a modest revival in discretionary spending by clients.

“Accenture’s results, commentary and guidance are slightly positive for Indian IT. Guidance of recovery in consulting business alludes to early signs of possible recovery in discretionary spends, though not in the immediate future,” Nuvama said in a report. “We... maintain that Gen AI will eventually lead to expansion of TAM for Indian IT companies.” Not long ago, Tata Consultancy Services (TCS) trumped both Accenture and IBM in the market capitalization sweepstakes. So, re-establishing relevance in the AI era - with billions of dollars in idle cash on balance sheets - shouldn’t be beyond the reach of top companies in a sector where India remains the unchallenged global leader.

Policy Doctor: Health Insurance Guide



SEGAR SAMPATHKUMAR
FORMER INSURANCE OMBUDSMAN, CHENNAI

Recently, my sister, 79, developed a urinary tract infection (UTI) and was treated at home for three days initially. But she had to be taken to a leading hospital in Noida as her fever persisted. The urine and blood tests confirmed the UTI prior to admission. When this hospital sent the pre-authorisation request for cashless approval, the standalone private health insurer rejected the application saying that treatment of kidney cysts is not eligible for coverage within two years (due to the waiting period). The hospital sent an application for reconsideration explaining that her UTI had nothing to do with kidney cysts. However, the request was rejected. I ended up paying the entire hospital bill of ₹86,000 out of my own funds. The reimbursement claim was also rejected twice, on the same grounds. To me, it seemed as if the company did not want to entertain the claim at all. The hospital, too, was more than happy being paid by the patient rather than the insurer; probably because the insurance company reimburses the hospital after a lag. Please advise on how I can

take my grievance forward. - Brig Kanwal Batra(Retd), Noida

The denial of the claim is unsustainable. If the treatment is not for kidney cysts and is essentially for a urinary tract infection, the claim ought to be paid. If the insurer rejects the claim, it is for the insurer to prove that the treatment was for cysts and for none other; and thus not payable. If the insurer is not able to prove such an allegation, the ground for denial fails, and the claim becomes payable. The insurer is also not permitted to adduce any other ground for rejection at a later point. As affirmed by the Hon’ble Supreme Court in the Saurashtra Chemicals case, it is a settled position that an insurance company cannot travel beyond the grounds mentioned in the letter of repudiation. The insured person (patient-policyholder) should again file a complaint with the insurer seeking payment of the claim. She can also file a complaint with the Grievance Redressal Portal of Irda (www.bimabharosa.irda.gov.in). In case the complaint is not resolved, she could approach the Insurance Ombudsman offices for relief.

an allegation, the ground for denial fails, and the claim becomes payable. The insurer is also not permitted to adduce any other ground for rejection at a later point. As affirmed by the Hon’ble Supreme Court in the Saurashtra Chemicals case, it is a settled position that an insurance company cannot travel beyond the grounds mentioned in the letter of repudiation. The insured person (patient-policyholder) should again file a complaint with the insurer seeking payment of the claim. She can also file a complaint with the Grievance Redressal Portal of Irda (www.bimabharosa.irda.gov.in). In case the complaint is not resolved, she could approach the Insurance Ombudsman offices for relief.

Have a health insurance query? Write to us at etwealth@timesofindia.com

UP opens doors to global markets

UTTAR PRADESH INTERNATIONAL TRADE SHOW (UPITS) BROUGHT BUSINESSES, BUYERS AND VISITORS TOGETHER, WITH STALLS SHOWCASING UP PRODUCTS, FACILITATING BUSINESS ENQUIRIES, BUYER INTERACTIONS, MARKET EXPLORATION AND POTENTIAL TRADE OPPORTUNITIES



UP INTERNATIONAL TRADE SHOW 2026

KEY FIGURES

BUSINESS	PARTICIPATION	GLOBAL SHOWCASE
₹6,500 Cr Business agreements	5.99 Lakh+ Total footfall	90 Countries represented
₹15,500 Cr Business enquiries	1.74 Lakh Domestic business buyers	60 Startups showcased
4,400 Business agreements / MoUs	2,400+ Exhibitors	15,000+ UP Police pavilion visitors
41,200 B2B meetings	600+ International buyers	



The fourth Uttar Pradesh International Trade Show (UPITS) 2026 concluded at India Expo Centre & Mart in Greater Noida after drawing participation from business buyers, exhibitors and the general public.

The trade show brought together businesses and buyers from across India and overseas, providing a platform to display a

wide range of products and explore business opportunities. Entrepreneurs and manufacturers showcased products spanning handicrafts, handloom, agriculture, food processing, leather, carpets, brass, glass, wooden products and other traditional and modern manufacturing segments.

Business buyers visited exhibition stalls to assess products, prices, production capabilities and potential for wider distribution and exports. The participation of domestic and international buyers also enabled manufacturers, traders and small and medium enterprises to interact with potential business partners and explore new markets.

With its combination of business interactions, product displays, skill demonstrations and cultural programmes, UPITS 2026 brought commercial and public participation together across the five-day exhibition

halls featured the state's traditional crafts, food products and cultural offerings, attracting a substantial number of general visitors.

Another highlight was the Uttar Pradesh Skill Development Mission pavilion, which featured 16 live skill demonstration centres. Visitors, including children and young people, could observe and participate in demonstrations showcasing different skills and vocational activities.



International business delegates and defence-sector professionals examined protective equipment at the Uttar Pradesh International Trade Show. The display featured tactical bulletproof vests and body armour, highlighting indigenous defence manufacturing. The scene also reflected the event's diverse industrial focus, bringing defence, manufacturing and other sectors together

School students interacted with a technical expert at the Uttar Pradesh International Trade Show, where they were introduced to advanced drone technology. The interaction reflected the event's focus on emerging technologies, defence innovations, startups and STEM awareness, giving young visitors an opportunity to explore indigenous technological developments



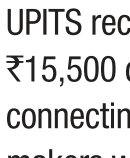
Five Days Of Business, Innovation And Ideas

The five-day event brought together businesses, buyers, entrepreneurs and innovators, creating opportunities for market linkages, partnerships, product showcases and new business connections

Hemp agricultural residue is being converted into textile fibre, with export MoUs signed for America and South Korea, creating opportunities for farmers and rural communities



60 startups showcased innovations across IT-ITeS, HealthTech, EdTech, agriculture, DeepTech and infrastructure, alongside selected innovators and Startup Fund ventures at the pavilion



UPITS records ₹6,500 crore in business agreements and ₹15,500 crore in enquiries, with 41,200 B2B meetings connecting MSMEs, manufacturers and local product makers with domestic and international buyers



Women's self-help groups signed around 30 MoUs with companies, opening direct market linkages, employment opportunities and larger business avenues

UPSDM's Skill Stage and 16 live demonstration centres engaged visitors with performances, interactive activities and hands-on exposure to diverse skills



The event also featured the launch of the One District One Cuisine (ODOC) portal, which brought together information on traditional foods, local products and culinary practices across Uttar Pradesh's 75 districts. The platform linked culinary heritage with food businesses, tourism, branding, market access and opportunities for local entrepreneurs



The Uttar Pradesh International Trade Show provided a platform for women entrepreneurs and self-help groups from across the state to showcase handmade, handicraft and lifestyle products to a wider market. Participants displayed brass artefacts, hand-painted garments, handmade suits, dupattas, lehengas, jute bags, bedsheets and other craft products. The event highlighted the growing role of women across the business cycle, from product development and branding to sales and market expansion. Several entrepreneurs had also created employment opportunities for other women through their businesses and self-help groups. The participation reflected how small, locally rooted enterprises were exploring larger domestic and international markets

Rel Retail, 7-Eleven End 5-Year Partnership

Sustainability issues force Indian co to exit franchisee deal; Japan's 7-Eleven may look for another partner here

Sagar Malviya

Mumbai: Reliance Retail and 7-Eleven are ending their five-year franchisee deal in India, closing most of the nearly 60 convenience stores they operated under the partnership, after struggling to make the format profitable, people familiar with the matter said.

A handful of outlets are clearing the inventory before shutting, they said. 7-Eleven may look for another Indian partner to keep a foothold in the market, although no decision has been made, the people said.

The exit highlights an unusual squeeze that convenience stores are facing in India, with millions of small kirana stores that have long served consumers' immediate needs on one side and quick-commerce companies that are bringing the same snacks, groceries and daily essentials to doorsteps within minutes on the other.

Reliance and 7-Eleven did not respond to ET's queries.

The partnership, struck in 2021, was intended to bring the world's largest convenience-store chain



to India through Reliance's retail network. But the business struggled to achieve the scale needed to offset the relatively high costs of running branded stores.

The 7-India Convenience Retail venture reported revenue of about ₹92 crore (\$10.6 million) and a net loss of nearly ₹90 crore in the year ended March 2026, according to its financial statements.

"Reliance wants to reach consumers across every channel, but sustainability ultimately matters. Convenience stores have faced increasing pressure from quick commerce since the pandemic, with both

formats offering similar assortments and serving the same immediate-needs occasions," said Devangshu Dutta, founder and CEO of Third Eyesight, a consumer-sector consultancy.

"Kiranas operate with far lower overheads and different margin expectations than corporate-run convenience stores. Reliance's exit could therefore signal a broader rethink of the format, particularly in markets where quick commerce has become a strong alternative."

Globally convenience stores have become powerful retail businesses in several markets despite the expansion of supermarkets and hypermarkets. 7-Eleven in Japan, Taiwan, Thailand and Singapore; Lawson in Japan and Oxxo in Mexico are among the largest retailers in their respective markets.

7-Eleven's Japanese parent, Seven & i Holdings, operates more than 85,000 stores globally, making it one of the world's largest retail networks. Yet the company has been restructuring its overseas operations and closing stores in North America as consumer behaviour and store economics change.

In India, however, organised convenience retail has struggled to replicate the success seen in other Asian and emerging markets. Easy-Day, More and Spencer's have either shut stores or shrank their smaller-format networks over the years, underscoring the difficulty of building profitable neighbourhood stores at scale.

Packaged consumer goods companies continue to derive roughly three-fourths of their sales from small neighbourhood stores, underlining the strength of the traditional distribution network. Quick commerce platforms are, meanwhile, expanding rapidly.

That makes it difficult for organised convenience stores to charge a premium or generate sufficient sales density to cover higher rents, staffing, inventory and logistics costs.

Convenience retail works best when operators achieve high store density and productivity, supported by strong supply chains and differentiated offerings such as fresh food and private labels.

Reliance initially expanded the 7-Eleven network in Mumbai and other markets, but the footprint remained small compared with the company's wider retail operations.

REGULATORY CHECK

FSSAI Orders Everest to Recall 'Unsafe' Cumin Powder

New Delhi: Food regulator FSSAI has directed Everest Food Products to recall 'pre-packed cumin powder' from the market after sample tests found it unsafe for consumption. The Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) also suspended the licence of Creative Bakers and Confectioners.

In a social media post on Sunday, FSSAI said it continues to enforce strict regulatory compliance to safeguard consumer health in the country.

"FSSAI licence of Creative Bakers and Confectioners has been suspended with immediate effect due to severe hygiene deficiencies," it said.

Moreover, the FSSAI has issued a product recall order against Everest Food Products. — PTI

CHANGING MARKET DYNAMICS

Consumer Firms Go Big on Smaller Towns as Urban Stress Takes a Toll

Brands step up distribution and last-mile delivery to new areas to boost sales in festive season

Ratna Bhushan

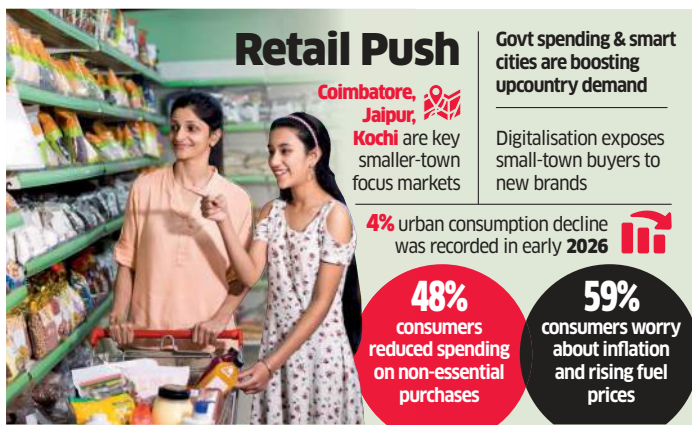
New Delhi: Consumer companies across sectors are banking on small cities and towns this festive season, as consumption in metros remains under stress.

Titan, Nykaa, Biba, Fabindia and Forest Essentials are among brands that are stepping up marketing, distribution and last-mile delivery to new localities in cities such as Jaipur, Coimbatore, Kochi, Lucknow, Indore and Bhopal, executives said. "About 70% of India's consumption is coming from breakout towns—the tier-2 ones; that market is playing out really well this festive season," said Rahul Shukla, chief sales and marketing officer, watches division, at Titan Company. "A lot of government policies, money flowing into upcountry towns, new smart cities getting made and digitalisation of the economy have exposed consumers to new brands, new trends, irrespective of which tier they are in," he said.

According to a recent report from market researcher Worldpanel, urban consumption dropped 4% year-on-year in the first quarter of 2026. As much as 48% of consumers cut back on non-essential purchases, with 59% consumers expressing concerns about inflation and increase in fuel prices, it said.

The small-town focus is playing out across sectors, with lifestyle brands including Biba, Fabindia and Forest Essentials releasing lower-priced products targeting such markets to attract first-time consumers.

IndoBevs, a homegrown company that makes spirits and liquors such as BroCode, Eden and Wingman, is strengthening its presence in tier-2 and emerging markets by investing in on-ground teams, distribution, and closer consumer and trade relationships, founder Sam Mahandru said. While the festive season "gives an opportunity to build on this momentum", the company's focus remains long-term, he said.



For celebrities, this means new revenue from advertising campaigns, branded entertainment and digital content. For emerging creators, identity licensing could provide an additional income stream alongside brand partnerships and platform monetisation.

AI May Turn Cash Cow for Creators, but with Risks

Javed Farooqui

Mumbai: Artificial intelligence is opening a new monetisation avenue for film stars, cricketers and digital creators, allowing them to license AI-generated versions of their faces and voices for commercial use without being physically present for every production.

For celebrities, this means new revenue from advertising campaigns, branded entertainment and digital content. For emerging creators, identity licensing could provide an additional income stream alongside brand partnerships and platform monetisation.

India's celebrity endorsement market is estimated at ₹3,000 crore, while its influencer marketing sector is projected at ₹3,500 crore, according to industry estimates. Cricketers Hardik Pandya and Shubman Gill are among the early adopters of AI cloning.

However, as generative AI makes it easier to replicate faces and voices, the commercial opportunity raises concerns over consent, unauthorised use and control of digital identities.

Studio Blo's FAIMOUS enables celebrities to create, control and license their AI clones, while Sparkonomy is launching the Open Creator Graph (OCG), an open infrastructure that allows creators to establish their identities and specify how AI systems can use their content and likeness.

With AI cloning, brands are no longer limited to celebrity shoots for ad campaigns. They can create images and videos of celebrities in different locations and situations to suit their creative briefs, said Dipankar Mukherjee, cofounder of Studio Blo.

"However, the much bigger benefit of cloning celebrities is what it unlocks in terms of branded content," he said. "The future belongs to monetisation of consent," he said. Sparkonomy is targeting a broader creator base. Cofounder Guneet Singh said AI could allow creators to license or lease their identities for content production, generating additional income alongside brand partnerships and sales commissions.



With AI cloning, brands are no longer limited to conventional celebrity shoots for advertising campaigns.

They can create images and videos of celebrities in different locations and situations to suit their creative briefs, said Dipankar Mukherjee, cofounder of Studio Blo. "However, the much bigger benefit of cloning celebrities is what it unlocks in terms of branded content," he said. "The future belongs to monetisation of consent," he said. Sparkonomy is targeting a broader creator base. Cofounder Guneet Singh said AI could allow creators to license or lease their identities for content production, generating additional income alongside brand partnerships and sales commissions.

"The key thing is that identity can now be replicated within 30 seconds. Creators who use their identity to make money need to be protected and compensated when someone else uses it. The opportunity is similar to that for celebrities, but at 1,000 times the scale," he said.

Rajesh Sethi, PwC India's leader for media, entertainment and sports, said widespread adoption would require standardised licensing terms, verifiable consent and systems to monitor usage, determine pricing and facilitate payments.

"The growing misuse of celebrities' and digital creators' identities through AI-generated deepfakes, voice cloning and face morphing has brought personality rights into sharper focus in India," he said.

Boards Step Up Scrutiny as Battle for Audit Mandates Hots Up Further

GRANULAR CHECKS Besides sector expertise, committees also examining data security and cyber controls as audit rotation cycle kicks in afresh

Vinod Mahanta

Mumbai: As top firms rush from one pitch to the next amid visible momentum in India's audit rotation cycle, audit committees and company managements are getting under the hood like never before while setting novel benchmarks in decision granularity.

They are putting incumbent auditors to the litmus test, scrutinising partners and teams down to the manager level, assessing sector expertise and bandwidth, poring over NFRA (National Financial Reporting Authority) reports for regulatory red flags, examining data security and cyber controls, and demanding to know what value audit firms could bring beyond simply validating financial statements.

In some cases, the scrutiny has become so granular that committees are even asking for partners' birth certificates to assess whether they are likely to remain in the job through the full audit mandate.

"Compared with the mandatory firm rotation (MFR) in

2017, I would say that the depth and quality of engagement in the auditor selection process have rightly increased significantly," said Samir Shah, audit leader, Deloitte Haskins & Sells LLP. "We are seeing a more mature, comprehensive and structured approach, with audit committees taking a much more active role in evaluating a wider range of factors."

BIG CHURN

A Prime Database study showed 1,030 audit mandates across 997 companies are due to expire in FY27. A further 314 audit arrangements across 305 companies are due for expiry in FY28.

Given how lucrative and widespread non-audit services have become for the Big Four firms—Deloitte, PwC, EY and KPMG—companies now want to settle the audit and non-audit services conflict issue first.

They are asking the audit affiliates what tax, advisory and other work can continue after an auditor rotation and how existing engagements will be transitioned if they need to.

"It is important to ensure auditor independence both in law and spirit. Accordingly, early conversations are about non-audit services or conflicts of interest, if any," said Sudhir Soni, head of audit at BSR, a KPMG affiliate.

"These arrangements can sometimes take time to resolve, which has led com-

panies to advance the auditor selection process. Companies want to ensure the transition is smooth."

In some cases, large audit firms are steering clear of audit mandates where non-audit work is significantly larger.

EY was the only large firm that continued to provide some non-audit services to audit clients but lately has been only providing some tax-related services. The firm says it follows "all applicable regulatory and professional requirements."

Audit partners say audit committees of leading companies are benchmarking the incumbent auditor on what it has done well, what needs to be strengthened and how gaps will be addressed.

Audit partners say audit committees of leading companies are benchmarking the incumbent auditor on what it has done well, what needs to be strengthened and how gaps will be addressed.

LOWER TAXES A KEY DRIVER

Small Beginnings! Auto Cos Bet on Compact Hybrids

About half a dozen small hybrids set to hit mkt in 2 years as third phase of CAFE norms takes effect

Sharmistha Mukherjee

New Delhi: Automakers from Maruti Suzuki to Hyundai, Toyota and Renault are set to drive in about half a dozen small hybrid vehicles to the Indian market over the next 18-24 months, supported by lower taxes on compact cars and to meet new fuel-efficiency regulations.

Maruti Suzuki is working on an affordable hybrid system that can go into small cars Fronx, Baleno, Swift and Brezza with the first of these due to hit the road next year, industry insiders said. The local unit of Korean automaker Hyundai Motor is readying a small hybrid vehicle for the Indian market for a mid-2027 launch, they said. Toyota's Indian unit is planning a hybrid version of the Urban Cruiser Taisor, which will follow the hybrid version of Maruti Suzuki Fronx, said the industry executives. Renault's sub-four-metre urban SUV based on the 'Bridger' concept, also featuring a hybrid powertrain, is scheduled for launch late next year.

Among mass-market carmakers, Maruti Suzuki, Honda Cars India, Kia and Toyota Kirloskar Motor sell hybrid vehicles like the Innova Crysta, Sorento and Grand Vitara in the local market, but all these models are priced upwards of ₹16 lakh, limiting customer acceptance. All these vehicles are more than 4 metres in length and attract GST at 40%.

"We expect hybrid technology to gain strong traction in India (with the launch of small affordable hybrid vehicles). It removes range anxiety while improving fuel efficiency, and hybrids retain better resale value than EVs, where battery-health concerns still weigh on used-car prices," said Gaurav Vangaal, associate director, light vehicle production forecast at Mobility Global.

"The sub-four-metre SUV segment is where the next phase will play out, with several carmakers expected to enter it with affordable hybrids, supported by lower taxes on compact cars and tighter CAFE (corporate average fuel efficiency) norms."

Small hybrid vehicles now attract a tax rate of 18%, compared with 43% prior to before the GST reforms introduced in September last year, which is prompting carmakers to increasingly consider the technology that helps address range anxiety concerns associated with EVs, while meeting the CAFE's regulations.

The third phase of CAFE regulations on fuel efficiency will come into force on April 1, 2027. Plug-in hybrids and flex-fuel strong hybrids are more fuel efficient when compared with pure petrol or diesel cars and get a 2.5 super credit multiplier under CAFE 3.

Strong hybrids get a 1.6 and flex-fuel ethanol vehicles get 1.1 super credit multiplier as per the latest norms set to kick in from April 1, 2027.

With sales of 2,793,303 units, the sub-four-metre segment accounted for 60% of the Indian car market last fiscal year.

Ready, Set, Go

125,000 Strong hybrid vehicles retailed in FY26
217,000 Electric cars retailed nationwide in FY26

40% GST applies to hybrids above four metres
18% tax supports compact cars with lower pricing

7 Strong hybrids selling in India's mkt



SBI
Transaction Banking Solutions Department, Corporate Centre, 21st floor, Maker Tower E-Wing, Cuffe Parade, Mumbai-400 005
E-mail - dgmmnbc.tbs@sbi.co.in, Website: https://sbi.bank.in

NOTICE INVITING TENDER
RFP No. SBI/TB-S/MLFF/2026-27/001 Date: 05.10.2026
Bids are invited by State Bank of India from eligible bidders for empannelment of System Integrator for implementation of Multi Lane Free Flow (MLFF) tolling system projects. Bidders, who are interested to submit bids, visit Procurement News at <https://sbi.bank.in/> and e-Procurement agency portal <https://etender.sbi/>.
Commencement of download of RFP: From 05.10.2026 at 18:00 Hours.
Last date and time for submission of bids: 26.10.2026 up to 18:00 Hours.
Place : Mumbai
Deputy General Manager (Projects)
Transaction Banking Solutions Department

CHITTARANJAN LOCOMOTIVE WORKS
CORRIGENDUM
Tender No.: 70/26/1134A, Date: 30/09/2026. Following corrigendum is prepared against the T/Case No. 70/26/1134A for procurement of "IGBT Based 3-Phase Drive Propulsion Equipment" i.e. Re-scheduling the Date of Tender Opening (TOD) From (existing): 30/09/2026. To Be Read As: 05/10/2026. AMM/HQ-II CLAW/Chittaranjan
PR2/506
"Like us on: www.facebook.com/clwrailways"

KARNATAKA CO-OPERATIVE MILK PRODUCERS' FEDERATION LIMITED
KMF Complex, Dr. M.H. Marigowda Road, DRC Post, Bengaluru-560 029.
Phone: 080-26096832/910/854 Fax: 080-25536105 E-mail: purchase@kmf.coop
IFT. NO. KMF/PUR/T-945/2026-27/Call-2 Date: 03.10.2026

TENDER NOTIFICATION (KMF/2026-27/IND2401/call-2)
The Karnataka Milk Federation, Bangalore invites tenders from eligible tenderers for supply of the goods & services as listed below:

SL No	Particulars	Approx. Qty. & EMD
1	Supply of Various Advertising Materials for Mother Dairy, Bangalore.	All the itemwise qty. & EMD details can be seen in the respective tender documents.

Tender documents may download from e-procurement portal website <https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in> Date of commencement of Tender Download – **03.10.2026 onwards**, Pre-Bid Meeting **06.10.2026 at 11.00 am**, Last date for submission of Tender **12.10.2026 at 15.00 pm**, Date of opening of Technical tender **13.10.2026 at 15.05 pm**, Date of opening of Commercial tender - **After technical Evaluation**.

For Karnataka Milk Federation Limited
Sd/- Director [Purchase]

Office of the Excise Commissioner
STATE EXCISE DEPARTMENT
2nd Floor, T.T.M.C. Building, 'A' Block, BMTC, Shantinagar, Bangalore-560 027.

No.: EXE/EAL/TENDER/01/2025-26(Part-1) Date: 03.10.2026

Short Term e-Tender Notification
(Two Cover System)

On behalf of the Govt. of Karnataka, Joint Commissioner of Excise (D&B), Office of the Excise Commissioner, Bengaluru invites e-Tender under KTPP Act 1999 and Rules made thereunder in Two Bid system from the eligible Manufacturers as stipulated in the tender document to Produce and Supply Paper-based Excise Adhesive Labels (EALs) as per the specifications and schedule of requirements mentioned in the tender document, by installing all the required infrastructure in the premises designated by the Excise Commissioner, State Excise Department, Govt. of Karnataka, Bengaluru. Tender fees & EMD is as per E-Procurement portal. The detailed tender document may be downloaded from website <https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in> for information. The bids shall be submitted through KPP Portal only. The details are given below.

1) Date of downloading of tender document: **05.10.2026, 10.00 a.m onwards**. 2) Pre-bid Meeting: **09.10.2026 at 11.30 a.m**. 3) Last date for online submission of tender: **19.10.2026 upto 5.30 p.m**. 4) Opening of technical bids: **22.10.2026 at 11.00 a.m**. The above offer may be contacted for any clarification or further information.

Sd/-
Joint Commissioner of Excise (D&B)
and Tender Inviting Authority

DIPR/CP/JA/3050/206-27

ROAD INFRASTRUCTURE DEVELOPMENT COMPANY OF RAJASTHAN LTD.
701-706, 7th Floor, ARG Corporate Park, Gopalnagar, Ajmer Road, Jaipur - 302 001
Tel.: +91 141 4127000, Email: csd@rdcor.in, Website: www.rdcor.in, GIN: U45203RJ2004PLC019850

GLOBAL INVITATION FOR EXPRESSION OF INTEREST FOR THE ACQUISITION OF EQUITY SHARES OF RIDCOR
Expression of Interests (EOIs) are hereby invited from Applicants for proposed acquisition of the equity shares of Road Infrastructure Development Company of Rajasthan Limited ("RIDCOR") constituting not less than 50% (fifty percent) and up to 100% (one hundred percent) of the paid-up equity share capital of RIDCOR on an 'as is where is' and 'as is what is' basis. RIDCOR is a 50:50 joint venture company between the Government of Rajasthan ("GoR") and Infrastructure Leasing & Financial Services Limited ("IL&FS") incorporated as a public limited company under Companies Act, 1956.
The sale process shall be completed via a two – stage process. Documents for EOI process can be downloaded from websites of www.ridcor.in or <https://pwd.rajasthan.gov.in/> or <https://shpp.rajasthan.gov.in/> or <https://www.ilfsindia.com/>. For any future information/ amendments/ corrigenda, kindly refer to above websites only.
Applicants who meet the eligibility criteria mentioned in the EOI, may submit their EOI in physical form at the address mentioned above, on or before October 26, 2026 by 5:00 PM (Indian Standard Time) with covering envelope clearly marked as "EOI for the Potential Transaction - [name of Applicant/ Consortium]".
Company Secretary

U. P. Power Corporation Ltd.
IT Unit, 5th Floor, Shakti Bhawan Ext., Lucknow-226001
Email: etender.itunit@uppcl.org

Notice inviting Tender Date: 03-10-2026
e-Bids are invited from interested bidders against **E-tender No. 04/IT/UPPCL/e-Wallet Based Bill Collection System/2026 Dated 03.10.2026** for Selection of an Agency for Implementation, Deployment, Operation and Maintenance of a e-Wallet Based Bill Collection System for UPPCL and Discoms. Tender can be downloaded from UP e-tender portal <https://etender.up.nic.in> for further details. Any changes, corrigendum etc. shall also be notified on the website. UPPCL reserves the right to reject any or all proposals or cancel the bid without assigning any reason thereof.
Ro. No. 16 Date: 03/10/2026

KARNATAKA CO-OPERATIVE MILK PRODUCERS' FEDERATION LIMITED
KMF Complex, Dr. M.H. Marigowda Road, DRC Post, Bengaluru-560 029.
Phone: 080-26096832/910/922 Fax: 080-25536105 E-mail: purchase@kmf.coop
IFT No: KMF/PUR/CPC/e-Proc./Tender-976/2026 Date: 30.09.2026

SHORT TERM TENDER NOTIFICATION
(Through KPP Portal only)
The Karnataka Milk Federation Ltd., Bangalore invites tenders from eligible tenderers for **Supply of 250gms Multi Layer Tray, Preform Tray Film (Bottom Web for Map) and Preform Tray Film (Top Web for Map) Film Under MAP Packing Materials**, for a period of Six Months Basis.
Tender documents may be downloaded from e-Procurement website <https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in> The tenderers may submit tenders for on or before **08.10.2026 up to 03.00 PM**.
EMD and other details can be seen in the tender document.
For Karnataka Milk Federation Limited
Sd/- Director [Purchase]

Let Exchange Rate Absorb Shock: IMF to India on Fed Hike Impact

PTI

Washington: The International Monetary Fund (IMF) has said the US Federal Reserve's decision to hike interest rates would contribute to tighter global financial conditions and suggested that India allow the exchange rate to act as a shock absorber. An IMF spokesperson on Friday said rate hikes by the Federal Reserve have historically created some pressure for emerging markets through capital flows, financing conditions, and exchange rate movements. On September 17, the Federal Reserve raised interest rates for the first time since July 2023 and indicated another hike could follow, as part of its effort to combat inflation.

DOMESTIC FACTORS

% IMF spokesperson said that, as with other countries, the impact on India would depend on the magnitude, pace, and persistence of the tightening cycle, as well as domestic economic conditions

The spokesperson said that, as with other countries, the impact on India would depend on the magnitude, pace, and persistence of the tightening cycle, as well as domestic economic conditions. "However, India enters this period from a position of strength. Strong growth momentum, a credible inflation-targeting framework, ample external buffers, and healthy corporate and financial sector balance sheets have strengthened the economy's resilience," the IMF spokesperson said. "In this context, allowing the exchange rate to act as a shock absorber, while keeping monetary policy focused on domestic price stability, remains an effective approach," the spokesperson said.

Gig Worker Unions Urge Karnataka Board to Roll Out Welfare Schemes

Say benefits promised under the law are yet to reach them

Our Bureau

Bengaluru: Gig workers' unions on Sunday urged Karnataka Platform-Based Gig Workers Welfare Board to adopt welfare schemes for platform workers, saying benefits promised under the law have yet to reach them. In a letter to the board's chief executive officer, Indian Federation of App-based Transport Workers (IFAT) and Karnataka App-based Workers Union (KAWU) sought immediate rollout of health and accident insurance, income support during medical emergencies and temporary disablement, maternity benefits, scholarships for children of platform workers and an emergency distress fund.

I-T Tribunal Gives Hope to Foreign Investors Post Tiger Global Shock

Relief in indirect share transfer case may offer treaty-based shield from Indian cap gains tax

Sugata Ghosh

Mumbai: An unexpected 'Irish tonic' can live up foreign investors put off by the Supreme Court's verdict that tipped the tax scales against American investment firm Tiger Global. In what could be a flicker of hope for many, a tax tribunal has spared a foreign company from capital gains tax on 'indirect transfer' of shares by seemingly skirting the apex court's stand in the Tiger Global ruling. While direct transfer is a straight sale of shares of a company in India by an offshore investor, indirect transfer is the overseas sale of shares of another foreign company (maybe in another jurisdiction) holding equity in an Indian company. Since many foreign direct and portfolio investments have indirect structures, the tax impact of overseas deals linked to Indian stocks and assets holds significance for many.

Seeking Relief

Gig workers' unions seek rollout of health and accident insurance & income support during medical emergencies

700,000
Estimated active gig workers in the state

- Aggregators have deposited welfare fees due under the law before the Karnataka High Court
- Unions want the board to use the funds for the benefit of gig workers

They have also sought portable pension, life insurance and retirement benefits that continue when workers change platforms or locations. The unions said there was an urgent need to provide social security to nearly 700,000 active gig workers in the state, citing income shocks and health emergencies they faced and the lack of accident protection. They noted that aggregators

had deposited welfare fees due under the law before the Karnataka High Court and urged the board to use the funds for the benefit of gig workers. The unions said no stay had been granted by the court and sought an urgent meeting of the board to formally adopt the welfare schemes. They also urged the board to invite worker representatives and other stakeholders for consultations to ensure the schemes address the concerns of platform workers. This comes amid the sta-

te having passed the Karnataka Platform-Based Gig Workers (Social Security and Welfare) Act, 2025 to create a statutory safety net for gig workers in the state. The law has been challenged in the Karnataka High Court by aggregators including Swiggy, Zomato and Uber, which have opposed the mandatory welfare fee imposed on platforms. The court has not stayed the law but has directed the platforms to deposit the welfare fees with the court pending the case.

Sigh of Relief

Direct transfer
Straight share sale by a foreign investor

Indirect transfer
Share sale of a foreign co with a stake in an Indian co

SC ruling on US firm Tiger Global questioned that

ITAT Delhi has now given relief

For years, investors from Mauritius and Singapore paid no tax on indirect transfer gains

For years, it was widely perceived that indirect transfer gains aren't taxed for foreign investors from Mauritius and Singapore—the main gateways for inflows—as India's treaties with them make no specific mention of such overseas indirect transfer of Indian securities. Though indirect transfer gains can be taxed under the Indian Income Tax (I-T) Act, foreign investors from treaty destinations escape it by deriving protection from treaties that prevail over domestic law.

However, in January 2026, the SC questioned this, saying that the indirect gains of Tiger Global weren't protected from tax by the India-Mauritius treaty. A Tiger Mauritius entity had sold shares of its Singapore arm holding equity in an Indian company. In its order released on September 30, the Delhi bench of the Income Tax Appellate Tribunal (ITAT), a quasi-judicial authority, ruled in favour of an Irish

BANK ON IMPROVED CONSUMER SENTIMENT
Appliance Makers Expect Festival Sales to Grow Despite Price Hikes

PTI

New Delhi: Despite a 5-8% increase in prices of air-conditioners and other consumer appliances ahead of the festive season, manufacturers are hopeful of recording double-digit growth in sales, led by premiumisation, replacement demand, easy financing and improved consumer sentiment. The latest price increase—the third round of revisions this year—has come ahead of the peak festive season, with higher costs of copper, aluminium, steel and crude derivatives, besides rising freight expenses and currency fluctuations prompting companies to raise prices. The industry, which started the festive season on a positive note with strong sales during Onam in the South, expects the momentum to continue through Navratri and Diwali, aided by premiumisation, replacement demand and easy availability of consumer financing. Consumers are increasingly opting for larger-capacity and feature-rich appliances, including energy-effi-



cient and smart connected products, which is expected to support value growth even as higher prices put some pressure on volumes, industry executives said. Some companies believe that it will have a minimal impact as dealers and distributors have already stocked inventory purchased at older prices through pre-buying schemes in August and September. When asked if the industry would record double-digit growth despite the price hikes, Haier Appliances India CEO NSSatish told PTI, "Definitely. It will." Haier India expects 30-35% growth in festive sales by value, while unit sales are likely to grow around 20%, he said.

10001/606/2627

DEPARTMENT OF HEALTH & FAMILY WELFARE
GOVERNMENT OF ODISHA

REQUEST FOR EXPRESSION OF INTEREST
OPERATION, MAINTENANCE & MANAGEMENT OF TRAUMA CARE CENTRE AT PANIKOILI, JAJPUR ON PPP MODE

Health & Family Welfare Department ("H&FW Department"), Government of Odisha intends to Operationalization of Trauma Care Centre (TCC) at Panikoiil on PPP mode. H&FW Department intends to select a private partner for commissioning, operation, maintenance and management of the Trauma Care Centre in Public Private Partnership ("PPP") mode ("Project") through a competitive bidding process. H&FW Department now invites Expressions of Interest ("EOI") applications from prospective reputed and professional healthcare providers interested in the Project. This Request for Expressions of Interest (REOI) is to commence a consultative process and does not constitute part of the bidding process. Subsequent to this announcement, H&FW Department reserves the right to follow an open competitive bidding process for selection of the preferred bidder for the Project. The EOI document can be downloaded from <http://health.odisha.gov.in/>. The EOI applications should be submitted to The Commissioner-cum-Secretary, Health & Family Welfare Department, Government of Odisha, Odisha Secretariat, Bhubaneswar - 751 001. The application can be submitted either through mail or through hard copy. The due date of submission of EOI application is **26.10.2026 by 17.00 hrs.** Please refer to the EOI document for further details. For further information/clarifications, please contact:

Shri Sashank Sekhar Dash Special Secretary to Government Department of Health & Family Welfare, Government of Odisha Odisha Secretariat, Bhubaneswar Telephone - 0674-2391164 Email: buildings.hfwodisha@gmail.com	Transaction Advisor: Shri Ananta Kishore Majhi Deputy Secretary to Government Mob: +91 9437304083 Email: buildings.hfwodisha@gmail.com
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OIPR-10001/10001/1/26-27/0009

ET THE ECONOMIC TIMES

THE FOUNDERS' GROWTH RETREAT

RESET • NETWORK • GROW

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THE AWARD THAT CERTIFIES EXCELLENCE IN WELLNESS.

TOI HEALING INDIA FORUM 2026

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SPOTLIGHT ON GST & REFORMS

Ease of Biz Relief in Store for Small Ecomm Sellers

GST Council may allow small sellers to sell nationwide with one registered address

Deepshikha Sikarwar

New Delhi: The Goods and Services Tax Council at its meeting Wednesday would consider a proposal to allow small sellers on ecommerce platforms to sell nationwide with a single registered address. If approved, this would benefit hundreds of thousands of sellers who, under existing GST rules, must have a registered place of business in every state they sell.

The council would also seek to place every online platform on the same footing in terms of who pays the tax on a service, addressing ambiguity on the issue, said people familiar with the proposals to be considered at the meeting.

Small sellers would be able to use an ecommerce platform's warehouses as their place of business in states where they do not have their own premises, the people said. They would need a physical presence in only one state where the physical verification of the address and Aadhaar authentication will take place.

Registration outside the home state can follow with the consent of the ecommerce platform whose warehouse they use, without requiring any intervention from the tax authorities, the people said.

This proposed change in the rule would enable even a small seller to sell nationwide with a single verified address. Ecommerce platforms, however, would be required to nominate a person responsible for providing information about the sellers, share verified seller data and report any changes such as the removal of a seller or alterations in his particulars.

As per data available, around 1.05 million sellers supply goods through ecommerce platforms.

Tax on Services Booked Online The council will also take up a proposal in connection with the long-standing dispute over who should pay GST on services booked through ecommerce platforms.

The law places the liability on platforms for certain services.

However, different platforms, particularly operating cab-booking services under divergent commercial arrangements, had interpreted the provision differently. The proposed definition seeks to place liability on the service itself rather than how a platform arranges its contracts.

Additionally, delivery of goods ordered on a platform will attract a 5% levy without credit in every case to ensure that the tax on a delivery is the same irrespective of the route.

Ecommerce platforms would be required to file their monthly collection statement even when no tax is collected, as per the changes proposed.

GST 2.0 – THE NEXT STEPS

A LOOK AT SOME OF THE PROPOSALS on the agenda of the Goods and Services Tax Council meeting on October 7 that seek to improve ease of doing business by simplifying processes. These proposals have already been discussed threadbare between central and state government officials at multiple meetings over the past nine months.

DECriminalISATION AND PROPORTIONATE PENALTIES

Arrest powers to be removed completely; tax disputes to be resolved through civil consequences

Prosecution provisions to be reworked; 9 provisions to be dropped, 24 softened and 11 retained

Threshold for prosecution raised to ₹5 crore from ₹1 crore

Sentencing reworked; no minimum sentence, with fines available as an option in all cases

Maximum sentence in the middle band to be reduced to 2 years from 3 years

Ordinary penalties to be rationalised

FARM SECTOR

A carve-out for storage & warehousing of seeds meant for sowing

A standalone exemption for curing of coffee supplied to cultivators

Seaweed-extract-based biostimulants included among fertilisers

All forms of psyllium seeds proposed to be at nil rate; no change proposed for raisins

MSMES

All three touchpoints—filing frequency, registration and maintenance, and notices for trivial amounts—likely to be addressed

Taxpayers to have a facility to file registrations for several states at once, with jurisdiction determined from geo-coordinates

No fee for late filing of returns for small taxpayers

DRUGS & HEALTH

Seven more rare diseases added to the list for which imported drugs, medicines and specialised foods are exempt

Credit on samples or goods destroyed or written off on expiry of shelf life

LOGISTICS, TRANSPORT AND WAREHOUSING

A vehicle may be stopped only where there is specific information

Decision to stop it to be authorised beforehand by a senior officer

Vehicle may be stopped only by the state where the goods originated

States through which the goods pass and the destination state would not intervene

Metro rail on the same footing as other rail movement

HELICOPTER SERVICES ON PAR WITH AIR TRAVEL

Shipping & logistics companies billing through overseas offices to receive export treatment

EXPORT SECTOR

Indian exporters can work through a branch office abroad

Job work done in India on goods belonging to a foreign client to be considered an export

Goods sold to a foreign buyer but delivered to an SEZ to be considered exports

Clarification on when export payment is treated as received

Pool of recoverable tax widened, with time-bound refunds

INPUT TAX CREDIT

INPUT CREDIT FACILITATION FOR SEVERAL SECTORS

A vehicle is treated as a business asset, with running costs and relevant credit allowed

Electric mobility placed on the same footing as conventional mobility

Credit mechanism to ensure hospitality services are taxed the same way whether sold directly or through an intermediary

HIGHWAY ASSET MONETISATION

As toll paid by a road user is exempt, the right to collect toll should also be exempt

The grant of the right to collect toll by a public authority has now been exempted

This is not a new exemption, but removes a charge on an exempt stream of revenue

Next-gen GST: Taking India's Reform Journey Forward



Nirmala Sitharaman

India's ambition to become a Viksit Bharat requires an economy in which enterprises of every size can grow, wherever they begin. Over the past 12 years, our government has worked to create those conditions. GST's introduction in 2017 established a common national framework for indirect taxation. Next-gen GST carries that effort forward, drawing on nine years of implementation and the experience of taxpayers and states.

Under Prime Minister Narendra Modi's vision, next-gen GST was conceived with two connected purposes: to reduce and rationalise rates, and to make compliance easier. The rate changes took effect on September 22, 2025. The next phase of process reforms will come before the GST Council shortly. Together, these efforts seek to give households relief, businesses greater certainty and taxpayers a system in which they can fulfil their obligations without avoidable difficulty.

States have been partners throughout. They brought their priorities and experience to the council, helped shape the decisions and undertook their implementation. I thank them for that commitment.

The results provide grounds for confidence. Between October 2025 and July 2026, the value of reported taxable supplies grew 25.8% over the corresponding period a year earlier. A lighter rate structure has been accompanied by a substantial expansion in reported economic activity. This is an encouraging foundation for a reform intended to support both enterprise and public finances.



That resilience is visible in the latest revenue figures. Gross GST collections reached ₹12.46 lakh crore during April–September 2026, up 11.6% from a year earlier. Every month from June through September recorded double-digit annual growth; together, collections for these four months accelerated by nearly 15%. Net collections, after refunds, grew 10.4% over the half-year. Taxpayer relief has coexisted with growth in the resources available for development.

The breadth of the expansion matters as much as its scale. Reported taxable supplies grew across all 11 sector groups and all major states. Growth across sectors and regions creates opportunities for more businesses to participate in expanding markets, and for more communities to benefit from the demand, investment and employment that follow.

Reported sales to consumers (B2C) rose 26.7% in the post-reform comparison. When tax relief is reflected in prices, families have more room to meet other needs or save. Consumer relief and enterprise growth are closely connected: the purchasing power of households sustains demand for the goods and services that businesses provide. The benefits can extend from the household to the retailer, the supplier and the

producer.

For small and medium enterprises, a national market is valuable when it opens a practical route to customers beyond their immediate surroundings. Businesses in tier-2 and tier-3 towns should be able to build those relationships while continuing to invest and employ people locally. Enterprises expanding into these towns, in turn, can create opportunities for local suppliers and distributors. GST's common framework supports these connections; simpler administration must make them easier to sustain.

Participation in that framework is substantial. GST registrations across central and state jurisdictions were about 17.1 million at the end of August, up nearly 15% from a year earlier. For the April–July 2026 tax periods, GSTR-3B returns filed by their due dates were 12.6% higher. These improvements place a corresponding responsibility on the administration: regular compliance must be supported by reliable service, clear guidance and timely resolution of difficulties.

The functioning of input tax credit is another important part of this experience. The post-reform figures show that the share of tax liability discharged through credits rose, while accumulated credit declined relative to taxable supplies.

This is encouraging for businesses that depend on the effective use of eligible credit. For a smaller firm, working capital determines how readily it can purchase inputs, fulfil an order and take on the next one. Refunds are equally relevant. About ₹1.80 lakh crore was refunded during April–September. Returning amounts due to businesses is part of a well-functioning tax system. Greater predictability in this process would help enterprises plan purchases and production with more confidence.

(The writer is the union minister of finance and corporate affairs.)

'US Deal Likely to Spur Further Liberalisation'

India's economic growth is maintaining its momentum, economist and 16th Finance Commission chairman **Arvind Panagariya** said. In an interview with ET's **Deepshikha Sikarwar** and **Kirtika Suneja**, Panagariya, who is also a professor of economics and the Jagdish Bhagwati Professor of Indian Political Economy at Columbia University, outlined several strategies to boost growth, including deeper trade liberalisation, increased privatisation, and reforms in the judiciary and energy sectors. He also emphasised the need to attract more long-term productive investment. Edited excerpts:

Experts have expressed concern over the sudden outflows of foreign capital from India. How do you perceive these outflows?

The first point to note is that, for years, what we have really talked about is gross foreign direct investment. Gross FDI figures have remained robust. There is nothing wrong there; it is growing very well. In fact, for the latest year, 2025–26, it is \$93–94 billion. That is very solid growth. The conventional figure that we have always used has continued to perform. This whole issue has come up because net foreign investment has declined. Why has it declined? There are two components: one is investment by our people abroad, and the other is repatriation. What has been happening is that, unlike China, FDI in India comes more in the form of private equity. Private equity has a cycle. Four or five years later, they want to exit. So there is automatically a built-in cycle—when the money comes in and then when it exits. These exits have become concentrated, and that has also caused a spike.

The fact that our people are now investing more abroad is a positive thing. I have no tears to shed if net foreign investment declines on account of our fellows investing abroad. That

HIGH TARIFFS, NON-TARIFF MEASURES AND TARIFF INVERSION CAN AFFECT INDIA'S COMPETITIVENESS AGAINST CHINA AND VIETNAM

Kind of cross-investing is a great thing, and it increases India's footprint abroad. Foreign investment, to me, is not so much about how much funds I can get. You can always overvalue your exchange rate and run a current account deficit if you want all the flows to come in. But you don't want to do that. It is not about funds; it is about direct foreign investment.

The question we need to ask is: why are we getting so much foreign investment in private equity? Why are we not getting investors directly investing in creating their own companies? That is where we need to look at things like our bilateral investment treaties... It reflects a lot less on the Indian economy. It reflects on the Indian economy only to the extent that private equity is the principal form of direct foreign investment into India. That, I think, is something that needs to be closely analysed. Why are we not getting firms investing directly in creating companies—a Foxconn, for example? That is a much more conventional form of investment. Otherwise, the cycle of exits continues.

So, is it mainly domestic factors that are impacting inflows, or do you see geopolitics and geoeconomics playing a role?

No, I don't think so. Why is gross investment growing so strongly? It is growing very solidly. So I don't think that is the main story.

On trade deals, the UK FTA is effective, the European Union FTA is done. In terms of India's overall trade strategy, how do you see this shift in trade deals playing out?

For me, the impactful deals are the UK and the European Union. The European Union is the one where I expect the impact to be much greater.

How significant is a US trade deal for India, not only for tariffs but otherwise as well?

Geopolitically, I think it is a good thing. But right now, geopolitics seems to be going in the opposite direction. I also see it as something that could facilitate our own liberalisation. It is difficult for India to liberalise on its own. But as part of an FTA, we may liberalise a lot more because the other country insists, and access to its market becomes contingent on getting access to our market. That creates a situation in which we can also liberalise our markets. Unilaterally, countries don't easily do that. There was a time when we did it—from 1991 to 2007. There was a very steady liberalisation of tariffs, in addition to import licensing, which was completely dismantled. But after that, we have not really naturally liberalised. So, politically, this is the sense in which a US-India agreement would be very useful.

FOR FULL INTERVIEW, GO TO www.economictimes.com

To me, the impactful deals are the UK and the European Union. The European Union is the one where I expect the impact to be much greater

ARVIND PANAGARIYA
ECONOMIST & 16TH FINANCE COMMISSION CHAIRMAN

Economy Within Striking Distance of 8% Growth, Resilience Not Accidental: Das

Our Bureau

New Delhi: India is within striking distance of 8% economic growth and measures focused on artificial intelligence, long-term capital, strategic self-reliance, sustainable development and human capital will be key to realise Viksit Bharat 2047, Shaktikanta Das, principal secretary-2 to the prime minister, said on Sunday.

"India's resilience is not accidental; it is the outcome of broad and mutually reinforcing reforms," Das said at the Kautilya Economic Conclave. "As we advance towards Viksit Bharat 2047, sustaining the reform momentum is very critical."

India's strategy is no longer to simply grow rapidly but to grow sustainably and resiliently over the long term, he said.

The country's real gross domestic product (GDP) grew 7.8% year-on-year in the first quarter of FY27 despite geopolitical uncertainties, with strong domestic demand and investment conditions. Das noted that the current global economic situation is marked by wars, fragmentation, unilateralism, tech blockades, energy price volatility and rising inflation. "The interplay of these forces is creating uncertainty across the world and would stifle global growth," he said, adding that what is likely to follow is restrictive monetary policy by central banks.



Many of the reforms undertaken over the past decade were not designed as one-off measures, but as strategic buffers to enable the economy to absorb disruptions & recover rapidly

SHAKTIKANTA DAS
Principal Secretary-2 to PM

Even more critical are high public debt levels in many advanced economies, resulting in rising bond yields, lower fiscal space, and the ability of countries to counter current and future shocks, he cautioned.

Das listed strengthening governance and state capacity, building macroeconomic stability and investment in long-term productive capacity as the three factors behind India's resilience.

"A distinguishing feature of India's development journey in the last 12 years has been the gradual creation of governance foundations before the crisis actually emerged," he said. These include strengthening governance and state capacity, building macroeconomic stability through measures including flexible inflation targeting, fiscal prudence and better quality of expenditure, tax reforms and market integration, restoration of

the health of the financial sector as well as prudent management of the external sector, he said.

"India is better positioned to withstand shocks," Das said, noting that investment in long-term productive capacity and diversifying energy sources helped boost the country's resilience.

Referring to the government's thrust on infrastructure spending and structural reforms over the last decade, he said India's policy emphasis on fiscal consolidation and sustainable debt may be seen in this context.

"Many of the reforms undertaken over the past decade were not designed as one-off measures, but as strategic buffers to enable the economy to absorb disruptions and recover rapidly," Das said, and put flexible inflation targeting, introduction of GST, the big push for digital payments and banking reforms among others in this category.

Over the past decade, improvements in public infrastructure, financial inclusion, housing, household electrification, sanitation, digital services and welfare delivery have contributed to stronger citizen-state engagement, he said. "When citizens experience tangible improvements in their lives, confidence in institutions increases. This confidence becomes a critical resource for governments seeking to undertake difficult reforms."

As per Das, adoption of Flexible Inflation Targeting (FIT) since 2016 enabled India to navigate through the successive shocks of Covid-19, war in Ukraine and the current conflicts in West Asia, and has provided the bedrock for its high growth. "India's external sector indicators have remained broadly resilient due to a mix of factors like the ongoing diversification of exports, conclusion of free trade agreements (FTAs), sustained surplus in services trade and steady inward remittances," he said.

A 3-PRONGED APPROACH

Das said the government's emphasis is on building domestic capacity in areas where the country is import dependent, develop long-term capabilities in critical areas such as energy and fertilisers, and continuously focus on economic stability.

FOR FULL REPORT, GO TO www.economictimes.com



Pvt Investment Picking Up Again: DEA Secretary

Our Bureau

New Delhi: Economic affairs secretary Anuradha Thakur on Sunday said surpluses and deficits become sources of friction and the price of capital rises when trade is organised around security and geostrategic concerns.

Addressing the Kautilya Economic Conclave, she expressed hope that the rules of the game still play out and countries recognise the durability of partnership, and also said investment is once again leading growth.

"We have seen with dismay that private investment is not picking up but now, the results are beginning to show. Investment is once again leading growth," Thakur said, adding that investment is picking up in a challenging global environment where capital remains constrained. She said the sharp rise in global bond yields poses a challenge for emerging markets and that they are no longer only about monetary policy or fiscal deficit but also about artificial intelligence (AI). "Bond markets have always been important but are assuming a larger and larger share of it," Thakur said. Government bonds now amount to more than 80% of the global GDP, making sovereign bond markets the largest pool of investments and debt and the benchmark for the price of capital across the financial system, she said.

Noting that governments are borrowing heavily while investors are demanding greater compensation for inflation, fiscal uncertainty and duration risk, the DEA secretary said: "This has pushed up term premium and long-term yields... For emerging markets, this poses a huge challenge. Global bond markets set the opportunity cost of capital, and added to this aspect are global imbalances."

AI CAPITAL

Thakur highlighted that another dimension to the changing global capital landscape, which is beginning to change the demand for and potentially the price of capital is the AI investment cycle. "This is not limited to software or computing, it requires data centres, semiconductors, reliable electricity and transmission capacity... investments into which are creating significant demand for capital and are increasingly being financed through debt," she said.

More investments would require greater demand for savings, while higher borrowings would mean that financial markets have to absorb a large supply of debt.

Global bond yields, therefore, cannot be understood only in terms of monetary policy or fiscal deficits anymore, she said, highlighting that the scale of AI buildout is now part of that story. "Measures can be announced, but credibility that our country has earned is one that is gained through sustained efforts," she said, stressing the importance of a consistent and prudent fiscal path.

Textile Industry Grows, but Apparel Output Shrinks

New Delhi: The Centre's industrial output data, which showed robust growth in August this year, buoyed by the overall manufacturing sector's performance, indicated a prolonged contraction in apparel production, even as the upstream textile industry logged firm upward momentum.

According to the Index of Industrial Production (IIP) released by the Statistics Ministry last week, overall growth in August 2026 stood at 8% against 6.7% in the preceding month. Within the manufacturing sector, 18 of 23 industry groups have recorded positive growth in August 2026 over the year-ago month, MoSPI said in a statement. —PTI

Strait of Hormuz won't be Reopened until Seven Conditions are Met: Iran

Tehran holds firm on proposal made at UN assembly; no 'military solution' to this conflict: Araghchi

The Strait of Hormuz will not reopen until seven Iranian conditions set out in a June interim agreement with the US are met, state media reported Iran's parliament speaker Mohammad Baqer Qalibaf as saying on Sunday.

Iran presented a proposal during the UN General Assembly under which the Strait of Hormuz could be reopened and normal maritime passage restored within seven days if the conditions were met, with the US replying to this proposal last week via Qatari intermediaries.

"The position of the Islamic Republic of Iran is completely clear and firm, and the Strait of Hormuz will not be opened until our seven conditions, based on the Islamabad Memorandum of Understanding, are met," Qalibaf, who is Iran's top negotiator, was quoted as saying.

He said Washington "must understand that the period of dragging out the (diplomatic) process and dictating one-sided demands is over".

Separately, Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi said, "If our enemies again choose the path of military confrontation, our response will be stronger than before, and we will defend ourselves with even more force."

"There is no military solution, nor any solution based on new sanctions...only



A board reading 'The Strait of Hormuz remains closed' at Tehran's Revolution Square | AFP

negotiations based on justice and fairness" could end the conflict, he said at a gathering of foreign ambassadors.

NO NUCLEAR DISCUSSIONS

A Foreign Ministry spokesperson said on Sunday that Tehran had clarified its broad positions via mediators to the US response but that additional points remained to be communicated to Washington.

"The Americans' propositions are mo-

re or less in line with their previous positions, specifically on the nuclear issue. We told them our focus in this stage is the issue of the Strait of Hormuz and the return to security in this waterway requires clear steps from the US," spokesperson Esmail Baghaeisaid. He also denied Tehran had offered UN nuclear watchdog inspections of its nuclear facilities in exchange for US sanctions relief, saying Iran had not entered into nuclear discussions with Washington. **Agencies**

First Time in Decades Iraq Set to Move its Oil beyond the Strait

Iraq's state tanker company arranged a very large crude carrier to ship 2 million barrels beyond the Strait of Hormuz, marking a move toward offering oil outside the Persian Gulf.

Iraqi Oil Tankers Co. loaded a VLCC and arranged for it to sail through the strait "for the first time in decades," Director General Ali Qais Abdul Jabbar said. Previously, buyers would have arranged for supertankers to collect Iraqi crude at Basra, near the head of the Persian Gulf. The transit marks a shift in how Iraq markets its crude, with the state tanker company taking responsibility for moving a shipment beyond the critical strait. Delivering outside the Gulf could help Iraq reach refiners reluctant to send vessels through Hormuz and secure better prices, reducing the discounts needed to attract buyers to its southern terminals. **Bloomberg**

€1B MILITARY SUPPORT, €350M IN ENERGY SECTOR REPAIRS

Berlin Offers Aid to Kyiv amid Moscow's Threats



The sound of air raid sirens and explosions rang out in Ukraine's capital Kyiv on Sunday as German Chancellor Friedrich Merz visited President Volodymyr Zelenskyy, pledging support for Ukraine and urging Russia to halt its escalating attacks.

This comes as Russia said it would intensify attacks on Ukraine's infrastructure, just a day after Moscow's foreign ministry warned that foreign diplomats in Kyiv were in "mortal danger."

Merz will announce a package of measures including the release of €1 billion in military aid and €350 million for repairs in the energy sector, German government officials said. A deal for joint production of various kinds of drones is also due to be finalised.

The two leaders visited the badly damaged building of Ukraine's Academy of Sciences, where at least two people died in a drone strike last week as Rus-

sia pounded the heart of Kyiv with some of the most persistent drone strikes since the start of the war in 2022.

"I can only repeat it once again from this point: Mr Putin, put an end to this senseless war," Merz said. "We are ready for talks, we are ready to discuss bringing this war to an end, but these barbaric attacks on the civilian population of Ukraine must stop," he added.

Four air raid alerts were heard across the capital on Sunday morning, and explosions and air defence systems also sounded across the city.

One of the Russian strikes hit the Northern Bridge across the Dnipro River, damaging its roadway.

"The Russian armed forces will intensify strikes against military and military-industrial facilities, as well as related infrastructure in Kyiv and other regions of Ukraine," the Russian Defense Ministry said Sunday. **Agencies**

SECURITY LAPSES COME TO LIGHT

Flydubai Drama 'UAE Shared Crew Details with Israel ahead of Flight'

Authorities in the United Arab Emirates shared with Israel a list of passengers and crew ahead of the Flydubai flight on which a pilot attempted to seize control of the Israel-bound aircraft and crash it, regional officials said Sunday, raising new questions over how the attacker evaded detection.

With the investigation underway, preliminary details about the incident have highlighted several major security lapses. Officials already have said the Omani co-pilot had been barred from flying by his own country because of concerns about his extremist views. It also remains unclear how a citizen of Oman, an Arab country that has no diplomatic relations with Israel, was allowed to fly a plane load of Israelis to Tel Aviv.

The UAE, which is leading the investigation, said the co-pilot attacked the flight's captain with the cockpit's crash ax and tried to take control of the plummeting plane in a "terrorist attack" Wednesday. His actions nearly crashed the flight with 182 people on board before the Indian captain managed to open the cockpit door, allowing passengers and others to rush in and subdued the attacker.

The Shin Bet, Israel's domestic security agency, said the Transportation Ministry is responsible for vetting passenger lists from foreign flights. Transportation Minister Miri Regev told Israel's public broadcaster Kan that the security agencies are responsible for flight security and that her ministry wasn't given a list of passengers or any warnings. **AP**

'Mecca Pact Grouping to Meet Today'

A committee of the Mecca defence pact between Turkey, Saudi Arabia and Pakistan will hold talks in Riyadh on Monday, with Turkish ministers among those attending, the Turkish foreign ministry said on Sunday.

The leader of Yemen's Saudi-backed government announced on Sunday the beginning of a major military operation against the Iran-backed Houthis earlier on Sunday, aimed at seizing the territory under their control.

Pakistan's foreign minister said on Friday that Iran had suggested engaging Yemen's Houthis politically after attacks by the group, an idea that the Mecca defence pact committee would discuss at a meeting in Riyadh this week.

"The meeting will address recent developments in the region and the stage reached in the Alliance's institutionalisation efforts," according to the Turkish statement.

It said Turkish Foreign Minister Hakan Fidan, Defence Minister Yasar Guler and chief of the general staff General Selcuk Bayraktaroglu would attend the meeting of the pact's strategic political and defence committee, along with officials from Pakistan and Saudi Arabia. **Reuters**

Co-pilot's Australia Links under Investigation

Australian police said on Sunday that authorities there were investigating the "links to Australia" of a Flydubai co-pilot who attacked the captain on a flight to Tel Aviv.

The co-pilot of the flydubai flight 1073, which was bound for Israel from Dubai, attacked the pilot with an emergency crash axe, the United Arab Emirates prosecutor general said on Saturday, calling the incident a "terrorist attack".

The co-pilot of the flydubai jet was identified as Hammam al-Hammami, an Omani

national, two sources with knowledge of the investigation told Reuters.

UAE authorities did not immediately respond to a request for confirmation of his identity. Reuters could not reach al-Hammami for comment. Omani authorities have not commented. Flydubai has said a full investigation is under way.

Two sources briefed on the investigation said the co-pilot studied at a university in Melbourne, capital of the Australian state

of Victoria. Local media reports said he studied at RMIT university. RMIT told Reuters it had no comment.

"The Victorian Joint Counter Terrorism Team (VIC JCTT), comprising the AFP, Victoria Police and ASIO, can confirm it is investigating the man's links to Australia. An update will be provided at an appropriate time," an Australian Federal Police (AFP) spokesperson said, referring to the Australian Security Intelligence Organisation. **Reuters**

US Marine Held in Japan Murder Case

A US Marine stationed on Japan's southern island of Okinawa was arrested on suspicion of the murder of a Japanese woman, police said on Sunday. The suspect "killed the 39-year-old woman at a hotel in Naha and stole her wallet on Saturday", a local police spokesman said.

Crimes including rapes, assaults, hit-and-run and drunk-driving accidents by US personnel have long sparked protests on Okinawa, which bears a disproportionate burden of hosting about 70 percent of US military facilities in Japan.

US Ambassador George Glass posted on social media that he had spoken with Japan's foreign ministry and Okinawa's governor, offering "our sincere condolences and pledging full cooperation as the investigation continues".

PM Sanae Takaichi said Japan had lodged a protest with US authorities and called the crime "exceptionally brutal and vicious". **AFP**

Brazilians Vote in High-Stakes Poll

Brazilians queued in long lines to vote on Sunday in the first round of a tight election, following a campaign dominated by corruption scandals and accusations of US meddling.

The field of 13 candidates has been dominated by two clear frontrunners — leftist President Luiz Inacio Lula da Silva, 80, who is seeking a fourth term, and Senator Flavio Bolsonaro, the 45-year-old son of former President Jair Bolsonaro, who hopes to return his father's right-wing movement to power.

A victory for the senator would extend a wave of wins across Latin America by right-wing candidates aligned with US President Donald Trump, while Lula's reelection could create a headache for Washington, which has clashed with his government over trade and security.

Despite growing worries over sluggish economic growth, the campaign has offered meager policy debate, as both leading candidates skipped the major TV debates. **Reuters**



Saudi Arabia is set to cancel next year's Joy Awards, its star-studded answer to the Oscars or the Grammys, as financial strain and the Iran war hit the country's nascent entertainment sector, two people with knowledge of the matter said.

Held in January, the event has become the crown jewel of Riyadh's annual events calendar, drawing performers including Katy Perry and Robbie Williams this year and handing out awards in music as well as

other areas of entertainment and sport. The Gulf monarchy is also shelving plans to build one of its most ambitious stadiums for the 2034 FIFA World Cup, dubbed the NEOM stadium, two sources said.

The broader NEOM development project was introduced about a decade ago as a centerpiece of Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman's Vision 2030, an ambitious plan to diversify the economy and cut reliance on oil. **Agencies**

Britain to Scrap Curbs on Jury Trial

Britain will scrap plans to remove the historic right to trial by jury for defendants in less serious criminal cases, the government announced on Sunday, in response to sustained criticism of the proposals by many lawyers and politicians.

The decision by Andy Burnham, who became prime minister in July, to drop his predecessor Keir Starmer's policy comes as hundreds of prisoners were released early to stop prisons becoming full, in just one element

of a criminal justice crisis.

Plans to curb jury trials for cases where a jail sentence was likely to be less than three years would be abandoned, the Ministry of Justice (MoJ) said, which was broadly welcomed by the Criminal Bar Association and other groups.

Lawyers raised concerns over MoJ's decision to increase sentencing powers for magistrates, who hear trials for more minor offences without a jury, and the

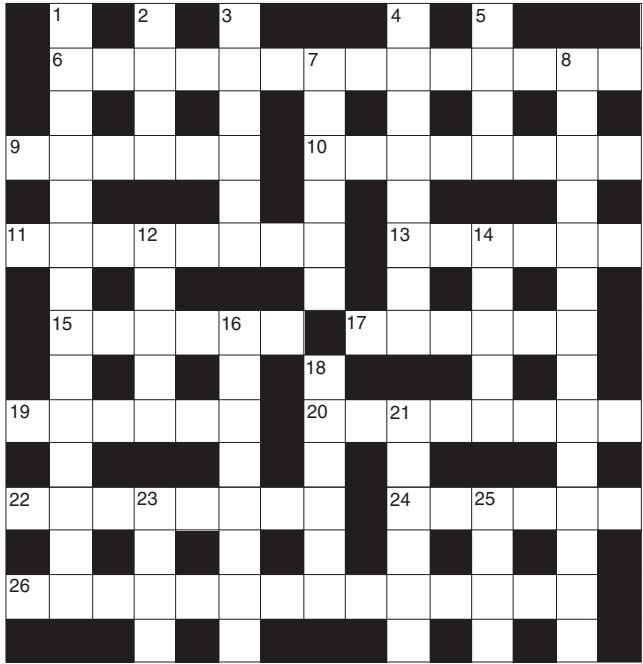
removal of defendants' right to elect trial by jury.

"I have heard the strength of feeling on the proposals for increasing the number of judge-alone trials in the Crown Court and have made the decision to change course," Justice Secretary Alex Norris said.

CBA chair Andrew Thomas thanked the government for "listening to the evidence and reaching the right verdict", though he said "a severe threat to our trial by jury remains". **Reuters**

Crossword

9721



ACROSS

6 Alter new bit of will? I've inserted part of sentence (8,6)

9 Doctor made us happy (6)

10 Expert opinions on wordplay? I'd turn and go (8)

11 Boar at it, chopped up? (8)

13 Engineers present normal good reputation (6)

15 Shed in field's not new (4-2)

17 Dance circle in part of railway carriage (6)

19 Note unstable tree — it may do this (6)

20 At start of year, accountant's involved with hearing (8)

22 Field will endlessly generate biodiversity (8)

24 Tiny greenhouse Cleo built, installing central heating (6)

26 Kentish beauty nearly in flower (10,4)

DOWN

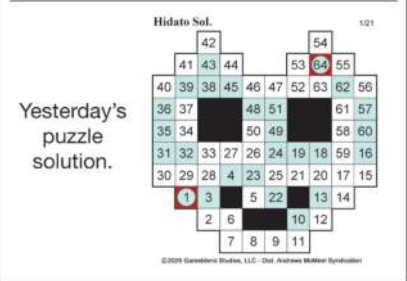
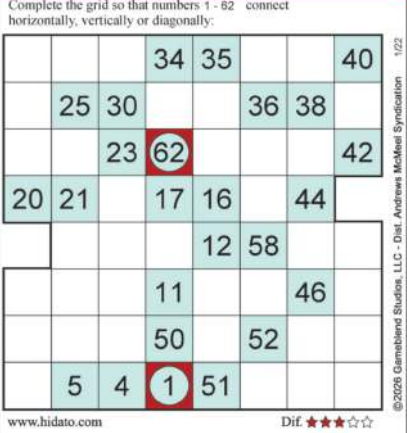
1 Darcey Bussell confirms her job after publicity (5,9)

SOLUTION TO No. 9720:

ACROSS: 1 Relives. 5 Throbs. 9 Devilry. 10 Ajaccio. 11 Awl. 12 Short shrift. 13 Theme. 14 Herbal tea. 16 Modernity. 17 Arena. 19 Indigestion. 22 Aim. 23 Eleanor. 24 Gladden. 26 Osirey. 27 Taffeta.

DOWN: 1 Radiant. 2 Level headedness. 3 Val. 4 Say-so. 5 Traitorly. 6 Reach. 7 Back in the saddle. 8 Portia. 12 Steer. 14 Hairspray. 15 Again. 16 Maiden. 18 Armenia. 20 Genie. 21 Ingot. 25 Alf.

HIDATO



7 LITTLE WORDS

Find the 7 words to match the 7 clues. The numbers in parentheses represent the number of letters in each solution. Each letter combination can be used only once, but all letter combinations will be necessary to complete the puzzle.

CLUES

1 wisecracking Parker (7)

2 impersonal conversationalist (7)

3 dirty quality (9)

4 Sean Connery or Brian Cox (4)

5 part of speech (9)

6 they're "on the record" (7)

7 smaller moon of Mars (6)

SOLUTIONS

1. sardonic (7)

2. impersonal (7)

3. filth (9)

4. Sean Connery or Brian Cox (4)

5. part of speech (9)

6. they're "on the record" (7)

7. smaller moon of Mars (6)

DOR	AD	OT	HY	KIN
TB	IVE	MOS	JE	ES
CT	OV	SC	MUC	CHA
ESS	DEI	OT	GRO	OT

Yesterday's Answers: 1. NAOMI 2. HOTEL 3. PIZZERIA 4. SWAZI AND 5. GRAZING 6. ELEMENTAL 7. FUZZY 11/18

For the mettle behind the medals,
the nation salutes you.



Sakshi Chaudhary

HUM KARKE DIKHATE HAIN

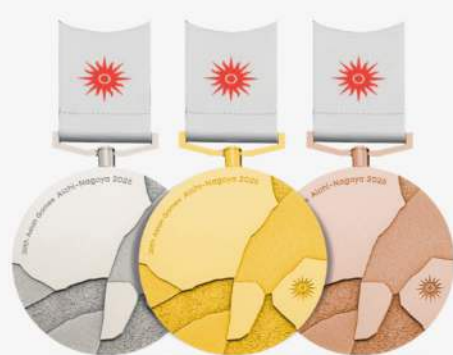
#GarvHai

85 MEDALS WON

GOLD: 21

SILVER: 27

BRONZE: 37



adani

Principal Partner of Indian Asian Games Team